

The Life of Christ & The Early Church: A Reformed Baptist Perspective

10th Grade New Testament Survey Textbook

Semester 1: The King and His Kingdom - The Life of Christ

Table of Contents - Semester 1

Course Introduction and Overview

- How to Use This Textbook
- Reformed Baptist Distinctives
- Scripture Memory Program
- Assessment Overview

Unit 1: Setting the Stage for the King (3 Weeks)

- Chapter 1: The Intertestamental Period - 400 Years of Silence
- Chapter 2: The Political and Religious World of the New Testament
- Chapter 3: Introduction to the Four Gospels

Unit 2: The Early Life and Ministry of Jesus (5 Weeks)

- Chapter 4: The Incarnation - The Birth of Jesus
- Chapter 5: The Preparation of Jesus - Baptism and Temptation
- Chapter 6: The Calling of the Twelve Disciples
- Chapter 7: Jesus' Early Miracles - Demonstrating Divine Authority
- Chapter 8: The Growing Opposition

Unit 3: The Teachings of Jesus - Parables and Discourses (6 Weeks)

- Chapter 9: The Sermon on the Mount - The Kingdom Ethic (Matthew 5-7)
- Chapter 10: The Parables of the Kingdom
- Chapter 11: The "I AM" Statements of Jesus (John's Gospel)
- Chapter 12: Miracles and Their Meaning
- Chapter 13: The Upper Room Discourse (John 13-17)
- Chapter 14: Final Teachings and Warnings

Unit 4: The Climax of the Gospels - Passion Week (4 Weeks)

- Chapter 15: The Triumphal Entry and Final Week in Jerusalem
 - Chapter 16: The Last Supper and Gethsemane
 - Chapter 17: The Trials, Crucifixion, and Death of Jesus
 - Chapter 18: The Resurrection - The Cornerstone of Faith
-

Course Introduction and Overview

Welcome to New Testament Survey

Dear student, you are about to embark on one of the most important journeys of your academic and spiritual life. This course will take you through the pages of the New Testament, focusing specifically on the life and ministry of Jesus Christ and the birth of the early church. As you study these sacred texts, you will not merely be learning ancient history, but encountering the living Word of God that has the power to transform your heart and mind.

This textbook has been carefully crafted from a Reformed Baptist perspective, which means we approach Scripture with deep reverence for its authority, accuracy, and sufficiency. We believe that the Bible is the inspired, inerrant Word of God, and that it speaks with clarity and power to every generation. As we study together, we will see how the New Testament reveals God's perfect plan of salvation through His Son, Jesus Christ.

How to Use This Textbook

This textbook is designed specifically for online learning, with interactive elements and practical applications that will help you engage deeply with the material. Each chapter follows a consistent structure:

Learning Objectives: Clear goals for what you should understand and be able to do after completing each lesson.

Scripture Foundation: Every chapter begins with key Bible passages that form the foundation for our study. All Scripture quotations are from the English Standard Version (ESV), which provides an accurate and readable translation of the original Greek and Hebrew texts.

Historical and Cultural Context: Understanding the world in which Jesus lived and the early church was born is crucial for proper interpretation of Scripture.

Theological Reflection: From our Reformed Baptist perspective, we will explore the deeper theological truths revealed in each passage.

Practical Application: God's Word is not merely for intellectual understanding, but for life transformation. Each chapter includes practical ways to apply biblical truths to your daily life.

Reflection Questions: These questions are designed to help you think deeply about the material and make personal connections to your faith journey.

Key Terms and Vocabulary: Important theological and historical terms are defined and explained.

Scripture Memory: Each chapter includes a key verse for memorization, building your foundation of biblical knowledge.

Chapter Quiz: Assessment questions to test your understanding of the material.

Reformed Baptist Distinctives

As we study the New Testament together, it is important to understand the theological framework that guides our interpretation. Reformed Baptist churches hold to several key distinctives that shape how we read and understand Scripture:

Sola Scriptura (Scripture Alone): We believe that the Bible is the sole infallible authority for faith and practice. While we value church tradition and the wisdom of godly teachers, Scripture alone has final authority in all matters of doctrine and Christian living.

Covenant Theology: We understand God's relationship with humanity through the lens of His covenants. The New Testament reveals the fulfillment of God's covenant promises made in the Old Testament, particularly through the person and work of Jesus Christ.

The Doctrines of Grace: Often summarized by the acronym TULIP, these doctrines emphasize God's sovereignty in salvation: Total depravity, Unconditional election, Limited atonement, Irresistible grace, and Perseverance of the saints.

Congregational Church Government: We believe that each local church is autonomous under the lordship of Christ, governed by its members under the guidance of qualified elders.

Believer's Baptism by Immersion: We practice baptism only for those who have made a credible profession of faith in Jesus Christ, and we do so by full immersion as the New Testament pattern demonstrates.

The Regulative Principle of Worship: We believe that corporate worship should be regulated by Scripture, including only those elements that God has commanded or clearly approved in His Word.

These distinctives will inform our study throughout this course, helping us to understand not only what the New Testament says, but how it applies to our lives as followers of Jesus Christ in the twenty-first century.

Scripture Memory Program

Throughout this course, you will be memorizing key verses that capture the essential truths of each chapter. Scripture memory is not merely an academic exercise, but a spiritual discipline that allows God's Word to dwell richly in your heart and mind. The psalmist declared, "I have stored up your word in my heart, that I might not sin against you" (Psalm 119:11, ESV).

Each chapter includes a memory verse that relates directly to the content being studied. You will be tested on these verses throughout the semester, and they will form the foundation for deeper theological reflection and practical application.

Assessment Overview

Your learning will be assessed through multiple methods designed to measure both your understanding of the material and your ability to apply biblical truths to contemporary situations:

Chapter Quizzes: Each chapter concludes with a quiz consisting of multiple choice questions, short answer responses, and vocabulary definitions.

Unit Exams: At the end of each unit, you will take a comprehensive exam that tests your understanding of the broader themes and connections within that section of study.

Reflection Papers: Throughout the semester, you will write short reflection papers that demonstrate your ability to apply biblical truths to personal and contemporary situations.

Scripture Memory: Regular assessment of your memorization of key verses.

Final Exam: A comprehensive examination covering all material from the semester.

UNIT 1: SETTING THE STAGE FOR THE KING (3 Weeks)

Unit Overview

Before we can properly understand the life and ministry of Jesus Christ, we must first understand the world into which He came. The New Testament did not emerge in a historical vacuum, but was written against the backdrop of centuries of political, religious, and cultural development. In this first unit, we will explore the 400 years between the Old and New Testaments, examine the complex political and religious landscape of first-century Palestine, and introduce ourselves to the four Gospel accounts that preserve for us the story of Jesus Christ.

As we begin this study, it is crucial to remember that God's timing is perfect. The apostle Paul reminds us that "when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law" (Galatians 4:4, ESV). The historical circumstances we will study were not accidents of history, but part of God's sovereign plan to prepare the world for the coming of His Son.

Chapter 1: The Intertestamental Period - 400 Years of Silence

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Explain the major political and cultural developments during the 400 years between Malachi and Matthew
- Understand how God was preparing the world for the coming of Christ
- Identify the key factors that shaped Jewish expectations of the Messiah
- Appreciate God's sovereignty in orchestrating historical events for His redemptive purposes

Scripture Foundation

"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons." (Galatians 4:4-5, ESV)

Memory Verse

"But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law" (Galatians 4:4, ESV)

Introduction: The Silent Years

When the prophet Malachi penned the final words of the Old Testament around 430 BC, the Jewish people could not have imagined that four centuries would pass before God would speak again through inspired Scripture. These 400 years, often called the "silent years" or the "intertestamental period," were anything but silent in terms of historical activity. During this time, empires rose and fell, cultures clashed and merged, and the stage was being set for the most significant event in human history: the incarnation of the Son of God.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, we understand that God's apparent silence during this period was not evidence of His absence or inactivity. Rather, these centuries demonstrate God's meticulous sovereignty as He orchestrated world events to prepare for the coming of His Son. Every political upheaval, every cultural shift, and every religious development served God's ultimate purpose of redemption.

The Persian Period (430-330 BC)

When Malachi concluded his prophetic ministry, the Jewish people were living under Persian rule, having returned from Babylonian exile under the decrees of Cyrus the Great. The Persian Empire, which had shown remarkable tolerance toward local religions and customs, allowed the Jews to rebuild their temple and reestablish their religious practices in Jerusalem.

During this period, the Jewish community was led by a succession of high priests and governors, including Ezra and Nehemiah, who had worked to restore not only the physical structures of Jerusalem but also the spiritual life of the people. The Law of Moses was read publicly and explained to the people, and there was a renewed commitment to covenant faithfulness.

However, the Persian period also saw the beginning of significant challenges that would shape Jewish identity for centuries to come. The Jewish community was small and vulnerable, surrounded by hostile neighbors and dependent on the goodwill of foreign rulers. This experience of vulnerability would contribute to the development of intense messianic expectations, as the people longed for a deliverer who would restore Israel's independence and glory.

The Persian Empire's policy of religious tolerance also had unintended consequences for Jewish faith. Exposure to Persian religious ideas, particularly Zoroastrianism with its emphasis on cosmic dualism and the struggle between good and evil, began to influence Jewish thought.

While the Jews remained firmly monotheistic, concepts such as angels, demons, and detailed eschatological expectations became more prominent during this period.

The Greek Conquest and Hellenization (330-167 BC)

In 334 BC, a young Macedonian king named Alexander the Great began a military campaign that would change the course of world history. Within a decade, Alexander had conquered the Persian Empire and established Greek rule from Egypt to India. When Alexander died suddenly in 323 BC at the age of 33, his vast empire was divided among his generals, but the cultural impact of his conquests continued for centuries.

The process of Hellenization—the spread of Greek language, culture, and ideas—profoundly affected the Jewish people. Greek became the common language of trade and diplomacy throughout the Mediterranean world, and many Jews, particularly those living outside Palestine, adopted Greek customs and ways of thinking.

One of the most significant developments during this period was the translation of the Hebrew Scriptures into Greek, known as the Septuagint (LXX). According to tradition, this translation was completed in Alexandria, Egypt, around 250 BC by seventy Jewish scholars. The Septuagint made the Hebrew Scriptures accessible to Greek-speaking Jews throughout the Mediterranean world and would later become the Bible of the early Christian church.

The influence of Greek philosophy also began to affect Jewish thought during this period. Some Jewish thinkers, particularly in Alexandria, attempted to synthesize biblical faith with Greek philosophical concepts. This intellectual movement would later influence both Jewish and Christian theology, though it also created tensions between those who embraced Hellenistic ideas and those who sought to maintain traditional Jewish practices.

Palestine itself was ruled first by the Ptolemies of Egypt (323-198 BC) and then by the Seleucids of Syria (198-167 BC). Under Ptolemaic rule, the Jews enjoyed relative freedom to practice their religion, but the situation changed dramatically when the Seleucids gained control of Palestine.

The Maccabean Revolt and Independence (167-63 BC)

The crisis that would define Jewish identity for generations came during the reign of the Seleucid king Antiochus IV Epiphanes (175-164 BC). Antiochus was determined to unify his empire through forced Hellenization, and he viewed Jewish religious practices as obstacles to his political goals.

In 167 BC, Antiochus issued decrees that struck at the heart of Jewish faith and practice. He forbade the observance of the Sabbath, the practice of circumcision, and the study of the Torah. He ordered the destruction of copies of Scripture and commanded Jews to participate in pagan

sacrifices. Most shocking of all, he desecrated the Jerusalem temple by erecting an altar to Zeus and sacrificing pigs on the altar of burnt offering.

This "abomination of desolation" sparked a revolt led by a priest named Mattathias and his five sons, the most famous of whom was Judas Maccabeus. The Maccabean revolt began as a guerrilla war but eventually succeeded in driving the Seleucids out of Jerusalem and rededicating the temple in 164 BC (an event still commemorated in the Jewish festival of Hanukkah).

The success of the Maccabean revolt led to a period of Jewish independence under the Hasmonean dynasty (142-63 BC). For the first time since the Babylonian exile, the Jewish people were ruled by their own kings. However, this period of independence was marked by internal strife, political corruption, and the gradual abandonment of the religious principles that had motivated the original revolt.

The Hasmonean rulers increasingly adopted Hellenistic practices and became more concerned with political power than religious faithfulness. They expanded Jewish territory through military conquest but also forced conversion on conquered peoples, creating resentment and instability. By the end of the Hasmonean period, the Jewish people were deeply divided along political, religious, and social lines.

The Roman Conquest (63 BC-4 BC)

In 63 BC, the Roman general Pompey captured Jerusalem and brought Palestine under Roman rule. The Romans initially allowed the Hasmonean dynasty to continue as client rulers, but political instability and civil war eventually led to the appointment of Herod the Great as king of Judea in 37 BC.

Herod, an Idumean by birth who had converted to Judaism, was a skilled politician and builder who managed to maintain Roman favor while attempting to appease his Jewish subjects. He undertook massive building projects, including the expansion and beautification of the Jerusalem temple, which became one of the architectural wonders of the ancient world.

However, Herod was also a paranoid and ruthless ruler who eliminated anyone he perceived as a threat to his power, including members of his own family. His massacre of the infants in Bethlehem, recorded in Matthew 2:16-18, was entirely consistent with his character and methods.

The Roman period also saw the development of the religious and political groups that would play important roles in the New Testament: the Pharisees, Sadducees, Essenes, and Zealots. Each of these groups represented different responses to the challenges of living under foreign rule while maintaining Jewish identity and faith.

Religious and Cultural Developments

The intertestamental period witnessed significant developments in Jewish religious thought and practice that would provide the context for Jesus' ministry and the early church's mission.

Synagogue Worship: During the Babylonian exile and the subsequent periods of foreign rule, Jews developed the institution of the synagogue as a center for prayer, Scripture reading, and religious instruction. By the first century AD, synagogues could be found throughout the Mediterranean world wherever Jewish communities existed.

Scribal Tradition: The traumatic experience of the exile and the threat of cultural assimilation led to an increased emphasis on the careful preservation and interpretation of Scripture. The scribes became the guardians of the biblical text, developing elaborate rules for copying manuscripts and interpreting the Law.

Apocalyptic Literature: The suffering and oppression experienced during the intertestamental period gave rise to a new genre of religious literature known as apocalyptic writing. Books such as 1 Enoch and 4 Ezra offered hope to suffering believers by revealing God's secret plan to vindicate His people and establish His kingdom on earth.

Messianic Expectations: The combination of political oppression, religious persecution, and prophetic promises led to intense speculation about the coming Messiah. Different groups developed different expectations: some looked for a political deliverer who would restore the Davidic kingdom, others expected a priestly figure who would purify the temple worship, and still others anticipated a heavenly figure who would establish God's eternal kingdom.

The Diaspora: By the first century AD, more Jews lived outside Palestine than within it. These diaspora communities, scattered throughout the Roman Empire, had developed their own forms of Jewish life and worship adapted to their Gentile environments. The existence of these communities would prove crucial for the spread of the Christian gospel.

God's Sovereignty in the Silent Years

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, the intertestamental period demonstrates God's meticulous providence in preparing the world for the coming of Christ. Every development during these 400 years served God's redemptive purposes:

Political Preparation: The rise and fall of empires created a unified Mediterranean world under Roman rule, with excellent roads and communication systems that would facilitate the spread of the gospel.

Cultural Preparation: The spread of Greek language and culture created a common means of communication that would allow the New Testament to be written and understood throughout the known world.

Religious Preparation: The development of synagogues provided ready-made centers for Christian evangelism, while the translation of the Hebrew Scriptures into Greek made the Old Testament accessible to Gentile converts.

Spiritual Preparation: The suffering and disappointment of the intertestamental period created a deep longing for redemption that would make many hearts receptive to the gospel message.

The apostle Paul's declaration that Christ came "when the fullness of time had come" (Galatians 4:4) reminds us that God's timing is always perfect. The 400 years of apparent silence were actually years of divine preparation, as God orchestrated world events to create the perfect conditions for the incarnation of His Son.

Reflection Questions

1. How does understanding the intertestamental period help you appreciate God's sovereignty in your own life, even during times when He seems silent?
2. What parallels do you see between the challenges faced by Jews during the intertestamental period and the challenges faced by Christians today?
3. How did the various political and cultural developments during this period prepare the world for the coming of Christ and the spread of the gospel?
4. What can we learn from the Maccabean revolt about the importance of standing firm in our faith when faced with pressure to compromise?
5. How do the messianic expectations that developed during this period help us understand both the acceptance and rejection of Jesus by different groups of Jews?

Key Terms

Intertestamental Period: The approximately 400 years between the completion of the Old Testament and the beginning of the New Testament.

Hellenization: The process by which Greek language, culture, and ideas spread throughout the Mediterranean world following Alexander's conquests.

Septuagint (LXX): The Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures, completed around 250 BC in Alexandria, Egypt.

Maccabean Revolt: The Jewish rebellion against Seleucid rule led by Mattathias and his sons, beginning in 167 BC.

Hasmonean Dynasty: The Jewish ruling family that governed Palestine during the period of independence (142-63 BC).

Diaspora: The Jewish communities scattered throughout the Mediterranean world outside of Palestine.

Apocalyptic Literature: A genre of religious writing that reveals God's secret plan for the end times and the vindication of His people.

Practical Application

The study of the intertestamental period reminds us that God is always at work, even when His activity is not immediately apparent. Just as God used the political upheavals and cultural changes of the ancient world to prepare for Christ's coming, He continues to work through the circumstances of our lives to accomplish His purposes.

When we face difficult times or periods of apparent silence from God, we can trust that He is still sovereign and that He is working all things together for our good and His glory. The 400 years of silence were followed by the greatest revelation in human history—the incarnation of the Son of God. Our times of waiting and uncertainty may be God's way of preparing us for blessings and opportunities we cannot yet imagine.

Chapter 2: The Political and Religious World of the New Testament

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Describe the structure and administration of the Roman Empire in the first century
- Identify the major Jewish religious groups and their distinctive beliefs
- Explain the role of the temple and synagogue in first-century Jewish life
- Understand the social and economic conditions that shaped daily life in Palestine
- Appreciate how these factors influenced the ministry of Jesus and the early church

Scripture Foundation

"Now after Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judea in the days of Herod the king, behold, wise men from the east came to Jerusalem, saying, 'Where is he who has been born king of the Jews? For we saw his star when it rose and have come to worship him.'" (Matthew 2:1-2, ESV)

Memory Verse

"Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's" (Mark 12:17, ESV)

Introduction: A World in Transition

When Jesus was born in Bethlehem around 4 BC, the world was experiencing a period of unprecedented unity and stability under Roman rule. The Pax Romana (Roman Peace) had brought an end to the constant warfare that had plagued the Mediterranean world for centuries, creating conditions that would prove ideal for the spread of the Christian gospel. Yet beneath this surface stability lay deep tensions between the Roman authorities and their Jewish subjects, tensions that would profoundly shape the context of Jesus' ministry and the early church's mission.

Understanding the political and religious world of the New Testament is essential for proper interpretation of the Gospels and Acts. The conflicts between Jesus and the religious leaders, the political maneuvering surrounding His trial and crucifixion, and the challenges faced by the early church all become clearer when we understand the complex dynamics of first-century Palestine.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, we recognize that God sovereignly orchestrated these historical circumstances to serve His redemptive purposes. The political structures, religious institutions, and social conditions of the first century were not obstacles to God's plan but instruments through which He accomplished the salvation of His people.

The Roman Empire: Structure and Administration

By the time of Jesus' birth, the Roman Empire had grown from a small city-state in central Italy to encompass virtually the entire Mediterranean world. This vast empire, stretching from Britain in the north to Egypt in the south and from Spain in the west to Syria in the east, was held together by a sophisticated system of government, law, and military organization.

Imperial Administration: The Roman Empire was ruled by an emperor (Caesar) who held supreme authority over all aspects of government. Augustus Caesar, who reigned from 27 BC to 14 AD, established the imperial system that would govern the empire for centuries. The emperor

was assisted by a complex bureaucracy of senators, governors, and local officials who administered the various provinces.

Provincial Government: Palestine was organized as a Roman province, though its administration was somewhat complex due to the special status accorded to the Jewish people. During Jesus' lifetime, Palestine was divided into several administrative regions: Judea and Samaria were governed by Roman prefects (later called procurators), while Galilee and Perea were ruled by Herod Antipas as a client king under Roman oversight.

The most famous of the Roman governors was Pontius Pilate, who served as prefect of Judea from 26 to 36 AD. Pilate's primary responsibilities were maintaining order, collecting taxes, and administering justice. His residence was in Caesarea Maritima, though he traveled to Jerusalem during major Jewish festivals to prevent disturbances.

Roman Law and Justice: One of Rome's greatest contributions to civilization was its legal system, which provided a framework for justice throughout the empire. Roman law distinguished between citizens and non-citizens, with citizens enjoying special privileges and protections. The apostle Paul's claim to Roman citizenship (Acts 22:25-29) illustrates the importance of this legal status.

The Roman legal system also recognized local customs and religious practices, allowing subject peoples to maintain their traditional ways of life as long as they did not threaten imperial authority. This policy of religious tolerance was crucial for the survival and development of Judaism under Roman rule.

Military Organization: The Roman army was the most effective military force in the ancient world, organized into legions of approximately 5,000 men each. In Palestine, Roman forces were stationed in key locations such as the Antonia Fortress in Jerusalem and the garrison at Caesarea Maritima. These troops served not only as a deterrent to rebellion but also as a visible reminder of Roman authority.

The presence of Roman soldiers in Palestine created constant tension with the Jewish population, who resented foreign occupation and the religious compromises it required. The Gospels frequently mention interactions between Jesus and Roman soldiers, illustrating both the pervasive presence of the military and Jesus' radical message of love for enemies.

Jewish Religious Groups

The Judaism of Jesus' time was not monolithic but consisted of several distinct groups, each with its own interpretation of Scripture and approach to religious life. Understanding these groups is essential for comprehending the religious conflicts described in the New Testament.

The Pharisees: The Pharisees were the most influential religious group in first-century Judaism, with an estimated membership of about 6,000. They emerged during the Maccabean period as champions of traditional Jewish law and practice against Hellenistic influence.

The Pharisees believed in the authority of both the written Torah and the oral tradition that interpreted and applied its teachings. They developed an elaborate system of rules and regulations designed to help Jews live faithfully according to God's law in every aspect of daily life. This "fence around the law" was intended to prevent violations of biblical commandments by establishing additional safeguards.

Theologically, the Pharisees believed in the resurrection of the dead, the existence of angels and spirits, and divine providence working alongside human free will. They looked forward to the coming of the Messiah and the establishment of God's kingdom on earth.

The Pharisees were generally popular with the common people because of their emphasis on personal piety and their accessibility as teachers and interpreters of the law. However, their meticulous attention to ritual details and their tendency toward self-righteousness often put them in conflict with Jesus, who criticized their emphasis on external observance at the expense of heart transformation.

The Sadducees: The Sadducees were a smaller but more politically powerful group, consisting primarily of the priestly aristocracy and wealthy landowners. They controlled the temple establishment and collaborated closely with the Roman authorities to maintain their privileged position.

Theologically, the Sadducees were more conservative than the Pharisees in that they accepted only the written Torah as authoritative, rejecting the oral traditions that the Pharisees embraced. However, they were also more liberal in their willingness to accommodate Hellenistic culture and Roman rule.

The Sadducees denied the resurrection of the dead, the existence of angels and spirits, and the concept of divine predestination. They focused primarily on the present life and the proper maintenance of temple worship according to the Mosaic law.

Because of their collaboration with Rome and their control of the temple, the Sadducees were generally unpopular with the common people. They viewed Jesus as a threat to their authority and were instrumental in His arrest and crucifixion.

The Essenes: The Essenes were a sectarian group that had withdrawn from mainstream Jewish society to live in isolated communities, the most famous of which was located at Qumran near the Dead Sea. They viewed the temple establishment as corrupt and looked forward to a time when God would purify His people and establish a new covenant.

The Essenes practiced a form of communalism, sharing property and living according to strict rules of purity and discipline. They believed in predestination, the immortality of the soul, and the coming of two messiahs—one priestly and one royal.

Although the Essenes are not mentioned by name in the New Testament, their beliefs and practices provide important background for understanding first-century Jewish expectations and may have influenced John the Baptist's ministry in the wilderness.

The Zealots: The Zealots were a revolutionary movement that advocated violent resistance to Roman rule. They believed that God's people should not submit to foreign domination and that armed rebellion was a religious duty.

The Zealots emerged as an organized movement during the first century AD and played a leading role in the Jewish revolt against Rome (66-73 AD) that resulted in the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple. Their uncompromising nationalism and willingness to use violence made them popular with some segments of the Jewish population but also brought devastating consequences.

One of Jesus' disciples, Simon, was identified as a Zealot (Luke 6:15), illustrating the diverse backgrounds of those who followed Jesus. However, Jesus consistently rejected the Zealot approach, teaching His followers to love their enemies and to seek a kingdom that was "not of this world" (John 18:36).

The Herodians: The Herodians were not a religious sect but a political party that supported the Herodian dynasty and its collaboration with Rome. They believed that Jewish interests were best served by working within the Roman system rather than opposing it.

The Herodians are mentioned in the Gospels as occasional allies of the Pharisees in their opposition to Jesus (Mark 3:6, 12:13). This unlikely alliance demonstrates how Jesus' ministry transcended traditional political and religious boundaries, creating new coalitions among His opponents.

The Temple and Its Significance

The Jerusalem temple was the center of Jewish religious life and the focal point of Jewish identity throughout the ancient world. Herod the Great had begun a massive renovation and expansion of the temple around 20 BC, creating one of the most magnificent buildings in the ancient world.

Temple Structure: The Herodian temple complex covered approximately 35 acres and was built on a series of terraced courtyards. The outermost area, known as the Court of the Gentiles, was open to all people and served as a place for teaching and commercial activity. Moving

inward, successive courtyards were restricted to Jews, Jewish women, Jewish men, and finally the priests.

At the center of the complex stood the temple building itself, containing the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place (Holy of Holies). Only the high priest could enter the Most Holy Place, and only once a year on the Day of Atonement.

Temple Worship: The temple was the only place where sacrifices could be offered according to Jewish law. Daily sacrifices were offered morning and evening, with additional sacrifices on Sabbaths, festivals, and special occasions. The temple also served as the center for the collection of the temple tax, which supported the priestly system and temple maintenance.

The temple's significance extended far beyond its role as a place of sacrifice. It was viewed as God's dwelling place on earth, the point where heaven and earth intersected. For Jews throughout the Mediterranean world, the temple represented the unity of their people and their special relationship with God.

Temple Personnel: The temple was staffed by a complex hierarchy of priests and Levites. The high priest served as the chief religious official and was responsible for the most sacred rituals, including the annual Day of Atonement ceremony. Below him were the chief priests, who supervised various aspects of temple administration, and the ordinary priests, who served in rotating courses throughout the year.

The Levites assisted the priests in various capacities, including serving as temple guards, musicians, and maintenance workers. The entire temple establishment represented a significant economic and political force in first-century Palestine.

The Synagogue System

While the temple was the center of Jewish religious life, the synagogue was the institution that most directly affected the daily lives of ordinary Jews. Synagogues could be found in every Jewish community throughout the Mediterranean world, serving as centers for worship, education, and community life.

Synagogue Worship: Synagogue services focused on the reading and exposition of Scripture rather than sacrifice. The basic elements of synagogue worship included prayers, the reading of selections from the Torah and Prophets, and a sermon or teaching based on the Scripture readings.

Any qualified Jewish man could be invited to read from Scripture or offer a teaching, which explains how Jesus was able to teach in synagogues throughout Galilee (Luke 4:16-30). The synagogue also served as a place for community meetings, legal proceedings, and the education of children.

Synagogue Leadership: Synagogues were governed by a council of elders led by a ruler of the synagogue (archisynagogos). This official was responsible for maintaining order during services and selecting those who would read Scripture and offer teachings.

The synagogue also employed a hazzan (attendant) who was responsible for the care of the Scripture scrolls and the physical maintenance of the building. In smaller communities, the hazzan might also serve as the elementary school teacher.

Educational Role: The synagogue played a crucial role in Jewish education, serving as both a school for children and a center for adult learning. Jewish boys typically began their formal education around age five, learning to read Hebrew and studying the Torah under the supervision of the local rabbi or scribe.

This emphasis on education and literacy was one of the distinctive features of Jewish culture and helps explain the high level of biblical knowledge assumed by the New Testament writers.

Social and Economic Conditions

The social and economic conditions of first-century Palestine provide important context for understanding Jesus' ministry and the early church's mission.

Social Structure: Palestinian society was highly stratified, with a small elite class controlling most of the wealth and power. At the top were the high priestly families, the Herodian dynasty, and wealthy landowners who collaborated with Rome. Below them were the merchants, artisans, and small farmers who made up the middle class.

The majority of the population consisted of peasant farmers, day laborers, and slaves who lived at or near subsistence level. This economic inequality created significant social tension and helps explain the appeal of Jesus' message to the poor and marginalized.

Economic Conditions: The Palestinian economy was primarily agricultural, with most people engaged in farming, fishing, or related occupations. The Romans imposed heavy taxes on the population, including tribute to Caesar, temple taxes, and various local levies.

Tax collection was often contracted to local tax collectors (publicans) who were allowed to keep whatever they collected above the required amount. This system created opportunities for corruption and made tax collectors extremely unpopular with their fellow Jews.

Religious and Cultural Tensions: The presence of Roman authorities and the influence of Hellenistic culture created ongoing tensions within Jewish society. Some Jews, particularly among the upper classes, embraced aspects of Greek and Roman culture, while others insisted on strict adherence to traditional Jewish practices.

These tensions are reflected throughout the New Testament in conflicts over issues such as taxation (Mark 12:13-17), ritual purity (Mark 7:1-23), and association with Gentiles (Acts 10:1-11:18).

Implications for Jesus' Ministry

Understanding the political and religious world of the New Testament helps us appreciate the radical nature of Jesus' ministry and message. Jesus entered a world divided by political loyalties, religious factions, and social inequalities, yet His message transcended these divisions while challenging the assumptions of every group.

Political Implications: Jesus' claim to be the Messiah had unavoidable political implications in a world where messianic expectations were often tied to hopes for political liberation from Rome. Yet Jesus consistently rejected the role of political revolutionary, teaching instead about a kingdom that was "not of this world."

Religious Implications: Jesus' conflicts with the religious leaders were not merely personal disputes but represented fundamental disagreements about the nature of true religion. His emphasis on heart transformation rather than external observance challenged the entire system of religious authority and interpretation.

Social Implications: Jesus' association with tax collectors, sinners, and other marginalized groups violated social conventions and challenged the existing social order. His teaching about the equality of all people before God undermined the hierarchical assumptions of first-century society.

Reflection Questions

1. How did the political structure of the Roman Empire both facilitate and complicate the spread of the Christian gospel?
2. What can we learn from the various Jewish religious groups about the dangers of emphasizing certain aspects of faith at the expense of others?
3. How did Jesus' approach to political and religious authority differ from that of the various groups of His time?
4. What parallels do you see between the social and economic conditions of first-century Palestine and contemporary society?
5. How does understanding the temple and synagogue system help us appreciate the significance of Jesus' teachings and actions?

Key Terms

Pax Romana: The period of relative peace and stability throughout the Roman Empire, lasting from approximately 27 BC to 180 AD.

Prefect/Procurator: Roman governors who administered provinces on behalf of the emperor.

Pharisees: A Jewish religious group that emphasized strict observance of the law and oral tradition.

Sadducees: A Jewish religious group consisting primarily of the priestly aristocracy who controlled the temple.

Essenes: A Jewish sectarian group that withdrew from mainstream society to live in isolated communities.

Zealots: A Jewish revolutionary movement that advocated violent resistance to Roman rule.

Synagogue: Local centers for Jewish worship, education, and community life.

Temple Tax: An annual tax paid by all Jewish males for the support of the Jerusalem temple.

Practical Application

The study of first-century political and religious conditions reminds us that the gospel message is always proclaimed within specific historical and cultural contexts. Just as Jesus and the early church had to navigate the complex realities of their time, we must thoughtfully engage with the political, religious, and social issues of our own era.

The example of Jesus shows us how to maintain our primary allegiance to God's kingdom while living responsibly as citizens of earthly governments. His interactions with people from all social and religious backgrounds demonstrate the universal appeal of the gospel and challenge us to cross the barriers that divide our own communities.

Most importantly, the political and religious turmoil of the first century reminds us that God's kingdom advances not through political power or religious manipulation, but through the faithful proclamation of the gospel and the transformation of human hearts by the power of the Holy Spirit.

Chapter 3: Introduction to the Four Gospels

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Explain the nature and purpose of the Gospel genre
- Identify the distinctive characteristics and themes of each Gospel
- Understand the concept of Gospel harmony and the Synoptic Problem
- Appreciate how the four Gospels complement each other in presenting Jesus Christ
- Apply Reformed principles of biblical interpretation to Gospel study

Scripture Foundation

"Now Jesus did many other signs in the presence of the disciples, which are not written in this book; but these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name." (John 20:30-31, ESV)

Memory Verse

"These are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name" (John 20:31, ESV)

Introduction: Four Portraits of One Savior

The New Testament opens with four distinct accounts of the life and ministry of Jesus Christ. These four Gospels—Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John—are not merely historical biographies but theological portraits designed to present Jesus as the promised Messiah and Son of God. Each Gospel writer, inspired by the Holy Spirit, selected and arranged his material to emphasize particular aspects of Jesus' person and work for specific audiences and purposes.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, we affirm that these four Gospels are equally inspired and authoritative, each contributing essential truths to our understanding of Jesus Christ. The differences between the Gospels are not contradictions but complementary perspectives that together provide a complete picture of our Lord and Savior.

Understanding the distinctive characteristics of each Gospel will enhance our study of Jesus' life and ministry throughout this course. As we examine the individual accounts, we will see how God used different human authors with different backgrounds and purposes to create a unified testimony to the person and work of His Son.

The Nature of the Gospel Genre

Before examining the individual Gospels, it is important to understand what kind of literature they represent. The Gospels are a unique literary genre that combines elements of biography, history, and theology.

Historical Foundation: The Gospels are grounded in historical events that actually occurred in first-century Palestine. The Gospel writers were not creating myths or legends but recording the words and deeds of a real person who lived, died, and rose again in human history.

Luke explicitly emphasizes the historical nature of his account, stating that he had "followed all things closely for some time past" and had consulted "eyewitnesses and ministers of the word" (Luke 1:2-3). The Gospels include specific historical details such as names, places, dates, and cultural practices that can be verified through other historical sources.

Theological Purpose: While the Gospels are historically accurate, they are not merely neutral historical records. Each Gospel writer had a specific theological purpose in mind and selected and arranged his material accordingly. John explicitly states his purpose: "these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God" (John 20:31).

The Gospel writers were not simply recording facts but interpreting the significance of those facts for their readers. They wanted their audiences not only to know what Jesus did but to understand who He was and what His life, death, and resurrection meant for humanity.

Selective Presentation: The Gospels do not attempt to provide exhaustive biographies of Jesus. John acknowledges that "there are also many other things that Jesus did" which are not recorded (John 21:25). Each Gospel writer selected those events and teachings that best served his particular purpose and audience.

This selectivity does not compromise the truthfulness of the Gospels but demonstrates the wisdom of the Holy Spirit in providing different perspectives on the same events. Just as four witnesses to an accident might emphasize different aspects of what they saw, the four Gospel writers emphasize different aspects of Jesus' ministry while maintaining complete accuracy in what they report.

The Gospel of Matthew: The King and His Kingdom

Author and Date: The Gospel of Matthew was written by Matthew (also called Levi), one of the twelve apostles who had been a tax collector before following Jesus (Matthew 9:9). Early church tradition unanimously attributes this Gospel to Matthew, and internal evidence supports this attribution.

Matthew was written primarily for a Jewish audience, probably in the 60s AD before the destruction of Jerusalem in 70 AD. The Gospel's emphasis on Old Testament fulfillment and Jewish customs suggests that the author was addressing readers who were familiar with Jewish law and tradition.

Distinctive Characteristics: Matthew presents Jesus as the promised Messiah and King of Israel. The Gospel begins with a genealogy tracing Jesus' lineage back to Abraham and David, establishing His credentials as the heir to the Davidic throne. Throughout the Gospel, Matthew emphasizes how Jesus fulfills Old Testament prophecies, using the phrase "this was to fulfill what was spoken by the prophet" or similar expressions more than any other Gospel.

The theme of the kingdom of heaven is central to Matthew's presentation. The phrase "kingdom of heaven" appears 32 times in Matthew but nowhere else in the New Testament. Jesus' first recorded words in Matthew are "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matthew 4:17), and much of His teaching focuses on the nature and requirements of this kingdom.

Matthew also emphasizes Jesus' role as the new Moses, the great teacher and lawgiver. The Gospel is structured around five major teaching sections (chapters 5-7, 10, 13, 18, 24-25), possibly paralleling the five books of Moses. The Sermon on the Mount (chapters 5-7) presents Jesus as the authoritative interpreter of God's law.

Key Themes:

- Jesus as the promised Messiah and King
- Fulfillment of Old Testament prophecy
- The kingdom of heaven and its requirements
- Jesus as the new Moses and authoritative teacher
- The inclusion of Gentiles in God's plan of salvation

Reformed Baptist Perspective: Matthew's emphasis on Jesus as King aligns with Reformed theology's understanding of Christ's threefold office as Prophet, Priest, and King. The Gospel's focus on the kingdom of heaven illustrates the already-but-not-yet nature of God's kingdom, which has been inaugurated through Christ's first coming but will be consummated at His return.

The Gospel of Mark: The Servant in Action

Author and Date: The Gospel of Mark was written by John Mark, a companion of both Peter and Paul in their missionary work. Early church tradition, particularly the testimony of Papias (c. 60-130 AD), indicates that Mark served as Peter's interpreter and recorded Peter's preaching about Jesus.

Mark is generally considered the earliest of the four Gospels, probably written in the late 50s or early 60s AD. The Gospel was likely written in Rome for a primarily Gentile audience, as evidenced by Mark's explanations of Jewish customs and his translation of Aramaic phrases.

Distinctive Characteristics: Mark presents Jesus as the Servant of the Lord who came not to be served but to serve. The Gospel emphasizes Jesus' actions more than His teachings, with approximately one-third of the narrative devoted to the final week of Jesus' life.

Mark's Gospel is characterized by a sense of urgency and movement. The word "immediately" (euthys in Greek) appears 42 times in Mark's 16 chapters, creating a fast-paced narrative that emphasizes Jesus' constant activity in service to others.

The theme of discipleship is prominent in Mark, with particular attention given to the failures and misunderstandings of the twelve apostles. Mark honestly portrays the disciples' struggles to understand Jesus' mission, providing encouragement for readers who face similar challenges in their own spiritual journey.

Mark also emphasizes the "messianic secret"—Jesus' frequent commands to those He healed or taught not to reveal His identity. This theme highlights the gradual revelation of Jesus' true nature and the difficulty of understanding His mission apart from the cross and resurrection.

Key Themes:

- Jesus as the Servant of the Lord
- The urgency and immediacy of Jesus' ministry
- The cost and challenges of discipleship
- The messianic secret and gradual revelation
- The centrality of the cross and suffering

Reformed Baptist Perspective: Mark's portrayal of Jesus as the suffering Servant aligns with Reformed theology's emphasis on the substitutionary atonement. The Gospel's honest depiction of the disciples' failures illustrates the doctrine of total depravity while demonstrating God's grace in using imperfect people to accomplish His purposes.

The Gospel of Luke: The Perfect Man

Author and Date: The Gospel of Luke was written by Luke, a Gentile physician who accompanied Paul on several missionary journeys. Luke is the only Gentile author of a New Testament book, and his Gospel reflects his careful research and literary skill.

Luke was written for a primarily Gentile audience, probably in the early 60s AD. The Gospel is dedicated to "most excellent Theophilus" (Luke 1:3), possibly a Roman official or wealthy patron who supported Luke's research and writing.

Distinctive Characteristics: Luke presents Jesus as the perfect Man who came to seek and save the lost. The Gospel emphasizes Jesus' humanity while never compromising His deity. Luke includes more details about Jesus' birth and childhood than any other Gospel, and he frequently mentions Jesus' emotions, prayers, and physical needs.

The theme of salvation is central to Luke's presentation. The Gospel contains more parables about lost things being found (the lost sheep, lost coin, and lost son in chapter 15) than any other Gospel. Luke emphasizes that Jesus came to save all people, regardless of their social status, ethnicity, or gender.

Luke also gives special attention to the role of women in Jesus' ministry, mentioning many women who are not found in the other Gospels. The Gospel emphasizes Jesus' compassion for the poor, the marginalized, and the outcasts of society.

The Holy Spirit plays a prominent role in Luke's Gospel, with more references to the Spirit than in Matthew and Mark combined. This emphasis on the Spirit's work prepares readers for Luke's second volume, the book of Acts, which chronicles the Spirit's role in the early church.

Key Themes:

- Jesus as the perfect Man and Savior of all people
- The universal scope of salvation
- Compassion for the poor and marginalized
- The role of women in God's plan
- The work of the Holy Spirit
- Prayer and worship

Reformed Baptist Perspective: Luke's emphasis on Jesus' perfect humanity supports Reformed Christology's affirmation of the hypostatic union—Jesus as fully God and fully man. The Gospel's focus on salvation by grace aligns with Reformed soteriology, while its emphasis on the Spirit's work resonates with Reformed pneumatology.

The Gospel of John: The Son of God

Author and Date: The Gospel of John was written by John the apostle, "the disciple whom Jesus loved" (John 21:20). John was one of the inner circle of disciples (along with Peter and James) and was an eyewitness to the events he records.

John's Gospel was probably written in the 80s or 90s AD, making it the latest of the four Gospels. The Gospel was written to combat early Gnostic heresies that denied either the full humanity or full deity of Jesus Christ.

Distinctive Characteristics: John presents Jesus as the eternal Son of God who became flesh to reveal the Father and provide eternal life. The Gospel begins not with Jesus' birth but with His eternal existence as the Word (Logos) who was "with God" and "was God" (John 1:1).

John's Gospel is structured around seven miraculous signs that demonstrate Jesus' divine nature and seven "I AM" statements that reveal His identity. These signs and statements build toward John's explicit purpose: "that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God" (John 20:31).

The Gospel emphasizes the themes of light and darkness, life and death, truth and falsehood. John presents Jesus as the source of spiritual light and eternal life who came to overcome the darkness of sin and death.

John also emphasizes the intimate relationship between Jesus and His disciples, particularly in the Upper Room Discourse (chapters 13-17). The Gospel contains Jesus' longest recorded prayer and His most detailed teaching about the Holy Spirit's ministry.

Key Themes:

- Jesus as the eternal Son of God
- The Word made flesh
- Signs and their significance
- Eternal life through faith in Christ
- The contrast between light and darkness
- The intimate relationship between Jesus and His followers
- The ministry of the Holy Spirit

Reformed Baptist Perspective: John's high Christology strongly supports Reformed theology's affirmation of Christ's full deity. The Gospel's emphasis on eternal life as a present possession of believers aligns with Reformed understanding of assurance of salvation, while its focus on God's sovereign choice (John 6:44, 15:16) supports Reformed soteriology.

The Synoptic Problem and Gospel Harmony

The first three Gospels—Matthew, Mark, and Luke—are called the "Synoptic Gospels" because they can be "seen together" (synoptic means "seeing together" in Greek). These three Gospels share much common material and often present events in similar order, while John's Gospel is quite different in structure and content.

The Synoptic Problem: Scholars have long debated the literary relationship between the Synoptic Gospels. Why do they share so much common material, yet also contain significant differences? Several theories have been proposed:

1. **Markan Priority:** Most scholars believe that Mark was written first and that Matthew and Luke used Mark as a source, along with other materials.
2. **The Q Source:** Many scholars propose that Matthew and Luke also shared access to a collection of Jesus' sayings (called "Q" from the German word Quelle, meaning "source") that is no longer extant.
3. **Independent Tradition:** Some scholars argue that the similarities between the Gospels result from their dependence on common oral traditions rather than literary dependence.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, the most important point is not the precise literary relationship between the Gospels but the fact that each Gospel is fully inspired and authoritative. The Holy Spirit guided each author to select and present material that served his particular purpose while maintaining complete accuracy.

Gospel Harmony: The differences between the Gospels do not represent contradictions but complementary perspectives on the same events. Just as a photographer might take pictures of the same subject from different angles to capture different aspects of its beauty, the Gospel writers present different aspects of Jesus' person and work.

When apparent discrepancies arise between the Gospels, Reformed hermeneutics seeks to understand how the accounts complement rather than contradict each other. This approach assumes the truthfulness of Scripture and looks for ways to harmonize the accounts while respecting the distinctive purpose and perspective of each Gospel.

The Unity and Diversity of the Gospels

While each Gospel has its distinctive characteristics, all four Gospels unite in presenting Jesus as the Christ, the Son of God, who died for our sins and rose again for our justification. The diversity of the Gospels enriches our understanding of Jesus without compromising the unity of their testimony.

Common Themes:

- Jesus as the promised Messiah
- The kingdom of God/heaven
- The necessity of faith for salvation
- The cost of discipleship
- The centrality of the cross and resurrection
- The Great Commission to make disciples

Complementary Perspectives:

- Matthew emphasizes Jesus' royal dignity as King
- Mark emphasizes Jesus' humble service as Servant
- Luke emphasizes Jesus' perfect humanity as the ideal Man
- John emphasizes Jesus' divine nature as the Son of God

Together, these four perspectives provide a complete portrait of Jesus Christ as Prophet, Priest, and King—the one Mediator between God and man who perfectly fulfills all of God's promises and purposes.

Implications for Bible Study

Understanding the distinctive characteristics of each Gospel has important implications for how we study and interpret the New Testament:

Respect Each Gospel's Purpose: When studying a particular passage, we should consider which Gospel we are reading and what that Gospel's distinctive purpose and perspective contribute to our understanding.

Use Gospel Parallels Wisely: Comparing parallel passages in different Gospels can enrich our understanding, but we should not assume that every detail must be identical. Each Gospel writer selected and arranged his material to serve his particular purpose.

Appreciate the Progressive Revelation: The four Gospels together provide a fuller picture of Jesus than any single Gospel alone. We should read each Gospel on its own terms while also appreciating how it contributes to the overall biblical testimony about Christ.

Apply Reformed Hermeneutics: We should interpret each Gospel passage in light of its immediate context, the broader context of that particular Gospel, and the even broader context of all Scripture. The analogy of faith principle reminds us that Scripture interprets Scripture.

Reflection Questions

1. How does understanding the distinctive purpose of each Gospel enhance your appreciation for the wisdom of God in providing four accounts of Jesus' life?
2. What can we learn from the fact that God chose to use four different human authors with different backgrounds and perspectives to tell the story of Jesus?
3. How do the different emphases of the four Gospels (King, Servant, Man, God) help us understand the fullness of who Jesus is?
4. Why is it important to read each Gospel on its own terms rather than simply harmonizing all the details into one composite account?

5. How does the diversity within unity of the four Gospels provide a model for how Christians with different backgrounds and perspectives can work together in ministry?

Key Terms

Gospel: A literary genre that combines biography, history, and theology to present the good news about Jesus Christ.

Synoptic Gospels: The first three Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke) which share much common material and can be "seen together."

Synoptic Problem: The scholarly debate about the literary relationship between the Synoptic Gospels.

Messianic Secret: The theme in Mark's Gospel of Jesus' commands not to reveal His identity.

Logos: The Greek word meaning "Word" used by John to describe Jesus as the eternal Son of God.

Gospel Harmony: The practice of comparing and coordinating the accounts of the same events in different Gospels.

Analogy of Faith: The Reformed hermeneutical principle that Scripture interprets Scripture.

Practical Application

The study of the four Gospels reminds us that God uses diverse people and perspectives to accomplish His purposes. Just as He used Matthew the tax collector, Mark the young missionary, Luke the Gentile physician, and John the beloved disciple to tell the story of Jesus, He continues to use people from all backgrounds to advance His kingdom today.

The complementary nature of the four Gospels also teaches us the value of listening to different perspectives within the body of Christ. While we must never compromise essential biblical truths, we can learn from believers who emphasize different aspects of the Christian faith or who approach ministry from different angles.

Most importantly, the four Gospels unite in calling us to faith in Jesus Christ as our Lord and Savior. Whether we are drawn to Matthew's presentation of Jesus as King, Mark's portrayal of Him as Servant, Luke's emphasis on His perfect humanity, or John's declaration of His deity, the ultimate goal is the same: that we might believe and have life in His name.

Unit 1 Review and Assessment

Unit 1 Summary: In this first unit, we have laid the foundation for our study of the New Testament by examining the historical context into which Jesus came and the literary context of the four Gospels that preserve His story. We have seen how God sovereignly orchestrated world events during the intertestamental period to prepare for the coming of Christ, how the political and religious world of the first century shaped the context of Jesus' ministry, and how the four Gospel writers each contributed unique perspectives to our understanding of Jesus Christ.

Key Concepts to Remember:

- God's sovereignty in preparing the world for Christ's coming
- The complex political and religious landscape of first-century Palestine
- The distinctive characteristics and purposes of each Gospel
- The unity and diversity of the Gospel testimony about Jesus

Scripture Memory Review:

- Galatians 4:4 - "But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son"
- Mark 12:17 - "Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's"
- John 20:31 - "These are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God"

Preparation for Unit 2: Having established the historical and literary context for our study, we are now ready to begin our detailed examination of Jesus' life and ministry. In Unit 2, we will study the early life and ministry of Jesus, from His incarnation through His early miracles and the growing opposition to His ministry.

UNIT 2: THE EARLY LIFE AND MINISTRY OF JESUS (5 Weeks)

Unit Overview

Having established the historical and literary context for our study, we now turn our attention to the person and work of Jesus Christ Himself. In this unit, we will examine the early life and ministry of Jesus, from His miraculous incarnation through the beginning of His public ministry and the initial responses to His teaching and miracles.

These events are foundational to our understanding of who Jesus is and why He came. The incarnation reveals the mystery of the God-man, fully divine and fully human. His baptism and temptation demonstrate His identification with humanity and His victory over sin. The calling of the disciples shows His method of ministry and the importance of discipleship. His early miracles reveal His divine authority and compassion. The growing opposition illustrates the spiritual conflict that would ultimately lead to the cross.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, these events demonstrate key theological truths: the reality of the incarnation, the sinlessness of Christ, the sovereignty of God in salvation, and the necessity of faith for salvation. As we study these foundational events, we will see how they establish Jesus' credentials as the promised Messiah and the only Savior of sinners.

Chapter 4: The Incarnation - The Birth of Jesus

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Explain the theological significance of the virgin birth
- Compare and contrast the nativity accounts in Matthew and Luke
- Understand how Jesus' birth fulfills Old Testament prophecy
- Articulate the Reformed doctrine of the incarnation
- Apply the truth of the incarnation to Christian living

Scripture Foundation

"And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth." (John 1:14, ESV)

Memory Verse

"Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel" (Isaiah 7:14, ESV)

Introduction: The Greatest Miracle in History

The incarnation of the Son of God is the central miracle of Christianity and the hinge upon which all of human history turns. When the eternal Word became flesh and dwelt among us, heaven touched earth in a way that had never happened before and will never happen again. This event, foretold by the prophets and accomplished by the power of the Holy Spirit, reveals both the depth of human need and the extent of God's love.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, the incarnation is essential to our salvation. Only one who was fully God could pay the infinite price required for sin, and only one who was fully human could serve as a suitable substitute for humanity. The virgin birth is not merely a biological miracle but a theological necessity that preserves both the deity and sinless humanity of Jesus Christ.

As we study the nativity accounts in Matthew and Luke, we will see how God orchestrated every detail to fulfill His ancient promises and accomplish His eternal purposes. The birth of Jesus is not just a beautiful story but the beginning of God's decisive action to redeem His people and restore His creation.

The Theological Significance of the Virgin Birth

The virgin birth of Jesus Christ is one of the fundamental doctrines of the Christian faith, affirmed by all orthodox Christians throughout history. This doctrine teaches that Jesus was conceived in the womb of the virgin Mary by the miraculous power of the Holy Spirit, without the involvement of a human father.

Biblical Foundation: The virgin birth is clearly taught in both Matthew and Luke's Gospels. Matthew records that Mary "was found to be with child from the Holy Spirit" (Matthew 1:18) and that this fulfilled the prophecy of Isaiah 7:14: "Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and they shall call his name Immanuel" (Matthew 1:23).

Luke provides even more detail, recording the angel Gabriel's announcement to Mary: "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore the child to be born will be called holy—the Son of God" (Luke 1:35). Mary's response demonstrates both her faith and her understanding of the miraculous nature of this conception: "How will this be, since I am a virgin?" (Luke 1:34).

Theological Necessity: The virgin birth is not an arbitrary miracle but a theological necessity for several reasons:

1. **Preservation of Deity:** If Jesus had been conceived through normal human procreation, it would be difficult to explain how He could be fully divine. The virgin birth demonstrates that Jesus' ultimate origin is not from man but from God.
2. **Sinless Humanity:** Reformed theology teaches that all human beings inherit a sinful nature from Adam through ordinary generation. The virgin birth explains how Jesus could be fully human while remaining sinless—He was not conceived through the normal process that transmits original sin.
3. **Fulfillment of Prophecy:** The virgin birth fulfills specific Old Testament prophecies, particularly Isaiah 7:14, demonstrating that Jesus is indeed the promised Messiah.

4. **Divine Initiative:** The virgin birth emphasizes that salvation is entirely God's work, not the result of human effort or planning. Just as Isaac was born through divine intervention to aged parents, and just as the nation of Israel was born through God's miraculous deliverance from Egypt, so the Savior was born through God's miraculous intervention in human history.

Historical Attacks and Defense: Throughout church history, the virgin birth has been attacked by those who deny the supernatural or who seek to reduce Christianity to merely human religion. However, the early church consistently defended this doctrine as essential to the gospel.

The Reformed Baptist position affirms the virgin birth as both historically factual and theologically necessary. We reject attempts to explain away the miracle through naturalistic theories or to treat it as merely symbolic. The virgin birth is a supernatural act of God that demonstrates His power to intervene in human history for the salvation of His people.

Matthew's Account: The Messiah's Royal Lineage

Matthew's account of Jesus' birth (Matthew 1:18-2:23) emphasizes Jesus' identity as the promised Messiah and rightful heir to David's throne. Writing primarily for a Jewish audience, Matthew demonstrates how Jesus' birth fulfills Old Testament prophecy and establishes His credentials as the King of Israel.

The Genealogy (Matthew 1:1-17): Matthew begins his Gospel with a genealogy that traces Jesus' lineage through Joseph back to Abraham and David. This genealogy serves several important purposes:

1. **Messianic Credentials:** By tracing Jesus' lineage through David, Matthew establishes His legal right to the throne of Israel. The Messiah was expected to be a descendant of David (2 Samuel 7:12-16), and Matthew demonstrates that Jesus meets this requirement.
2. **Covenant Fulfillment:** The genealogy shows how Jesus fulfills God's covenant promises to Abraham (that all nations would be blessed through his seed) and to David (that his throne would be established forever).
3. **Divine Providence:** The inclusion of women in the genealogy (Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, and Bathsheba) demonstrates God's grace in using imperfect people to accomplish His perfect purposes. These women, some of whom were Gentiles or had questionable backgrounds, show that God's plan of salvation extends beyond ethnic Israel.

4. **Historical Accuracy:** The genealogy demonstrates that Jesus was a real historical person with verifiable ancestry, not a mythical figure.

The Virgin Birth (Matthew 1:18-25): Matthew's account of the virgin birth emphasizes Joseph's role and his obedient response to God's revelation. When Joseph discovered that Mary was pregnant, he initially planned to divorce her quietly, demonstrating both his righteousness and his compassion.

The angel's message to Joseph reveals several crucial truths:

- The child was conceived "from the Holy Spirit" (v. 20)
- The child would "save his people from their sins" (v. 21)
- The birth fulfilled Isaiah's prophecy about Immanuel (vv. 22-23)

Joseph's immediate obedience to the angel's command demonstrates the kind of faith that God honors. He took Mary as his wife but "knew her not until she had given birth to a son" (v. 25), preserving her virginity until after Jesus' birth.

The Visit of the Magi (Matthew 2:1-12): The visit of the wise men from the east demonstrates that Jesus came not only for Israel but for all nations. These Gentile scholars recognized Jesus as the "king of the Jews" and came to worship Him, fulfilling the prophetic expectation that the nations would come to Israel's light (Isaiah 60:3).

The gifts of gold, frankincense, and myrrh have traditionally been understood as symbolic of Jesus' threefold office: gold for His kingship, frankincense for His priesthood, and myrrh for His sacrificial death. More practically, these valuable gifts likely provided the financial resources needed for the family's flight to Egypt.

The Flight to Egypt and Return (Matthew 2:13-23): Herod's attempt to kill the infant Jesus and the family's subsequent flight to Egypt demonstrate both the reality of spiritual warfare and God's sovereign protection of His Son. Matthew sees in these events the fulfillment of Hosea 11:1: "Out of Egypt I called my son."

The massacre of the innocents in Bethlehem reveals the depth of human depravity and the cost of opposing God's purposes. Yet even this tragic event serves God's plan by fulfilling Jeremiah's prophecy about Rachel weeping for her children (Jeremiah 31:15).

Luke's Account: The Savior of All People

Luke's account of Jesus' birth (Luke 1:26-2:52) emphasizes Jesus' identity as the Savior of all people, not just Israel. Writing for a primarily Gentile audience, Luke highlights the universal scope of salvation and the inclusion of the poor and marginalized in God's plan.

The Annunciation (Luke 1:26-38): Luke's account begins with the angel Gabriel's announcement to Mary, a young virgin in Nazareth. The angel's greeting—"Greetings, O favored one! The Lord is with you!"—reveals that Mary has been chosen by God's grace, not because of any merit of her own.

The angel's message reveals several crucial truths about Jesus:

- He will be "great" and "called the Son of the Most High" (v. 32)
- He will receive "the throne of his father David" (v. 32)
- He will "reign over the house of Jacob forever" (v. 33)
- "Of his kingdom there will be no end" (v. 33)

Mary's question—"How will this be, since I am a virgin?"—is not doubt but a request for understanding. The angel's explanation emphasizes the supernatural nature of the conception and the divine identity of the child.

Mary's response—"Behold, I am the servant of the Lord; let it be to me according to your word"—demonstrates perfect submission to God's will and serves as a model for all believers.

Mary's Song (Luke 1:46-55): Mary's Magnificat is a beautiful expression of praise that reveals her deep knowledge of Scripture and her understanding of God's character. The song emphasizes several key themes:

1. **God's Mercy:** Mary rejoices in God's mercy to her and to all who fear Him (vv. 50, 54)
2. **God's Power:** God has done "mighty things" and scattered the proud (vv. 49, 51)
3. **God's Justice:** God has brought down the mighty and exalted the humble (vv. 52-53)
4. **God's Faithfulness:** God has remembered His promises to Abraham and his descendants (vv. 54-55)

The Birth in Bethlehem (Luke 2:1-7): Luke carefully places Jesus' birth in its historical context, mentioning the census ordered by Caesar Augustus and conducted while Quirinius was governor of Syria. This historical detail demonstrates that Jesus was born into real history, not mythology.

The fact that Jesus was born in Bethlehem fulfills Micah's prophecy (Micah 5:2) while also demonstrating God's sovereignty in using even pagan rulers to accomplish His purposes. Caesar's census decree, intended to strengthen Roman control, actually serves to place Jesus in the city of David at the appointed time.

The humble circumstances of Jesus' birth—born in a stable because there was no room in the inn—emphasize the theme of God's identification with the poor and marginalized. The Son of God entered the world not in a palace but in the humblest of circumstances.

The Shepherds' Visit (Luke 2:8-20): The announcement of Jesus' birth to shepherds rather than to kings or priests demonstrates God's concern for the lowly and despised. Shepherds were considered unclean by the religious establishment and were often excluded from polite society.

The angel's message to the shepherds contains the essence of the gospel:

- "Fear not" (v. 10)—the gospel removes the fear of God's judgment
- "Good news of great joy" (v. 10)—the gospel is fundamentally good news
- "For all the people" (v. 10)—the gospel is for everyone, not just the elite
- "A Savior, who is Christ the Lord" (v. 11)—Jesus is the promised Messiah and divine Lord

The shepherds' response—they "went with haste" and "made known" what they had heard—demonstrates the proper response to the gospel: immediate action and enthusiastic witness.

The Presentation in the Temple (Luke 2:21-40): Jesus' circumcision on the eighth day and His presentation in the temple demonstrate His parents' obedience to the law and His identification with the covenant people of God. The offering of "a pair of turtledoves or two young pigeons" (v. 24) indicates the family's modest economic circumstances.

Simeon's prophecy reveals both the glory and the cost of Jesus' mission. He will be "a light for revelation to the Gentiles, and for glory to your people Israel" (v. 32), but He will also be "a sign that is opposed" and "a sword will pierce through your own soul also" (vv. 34-35).

Anna's testimony demonstrates that there were faithful believers in Israel who were waiting for the redemption of Jerusalem and who recognized Jesus as the promised Messiah.

The Doctrine of the Incarnation

The birth narratives in Matthew and Luke provide the foundation for the Christian doctrine of the incarnation, which teaches that the eternal Son of God took on human nature while retaining His divine nature.

The Chalcedonian Definition: The Council of Chalcedon (451 AD) formulated the orthodox understanding of the incarnation, declaring that Jesus Christ is:

- Truly God and truly man
- One person with two natures (divine and human)
- The two natures are united without confusion, change, division, or separation

This definition protects against various heresies that either deny Christ's full deity (Arianism), His full humanity (Docetism), or the unity of His person (Nestorianism).

Reformed Understanding: Reformed theology affirms the Chalcedonian definition while emphasizing several additional points:

1. **The Eternal Sonship:** The Son's relationship to the Father is eternal, not something that began at the incarnation. The incarnation is the assumption of human nature by the eternal Son, not the creation of a new person.
2. **The Communication of Properties:** While the two natures remain distinct, the properties of each nature are attributed to the one person of Christ. Thus, we can say that God died on the cross (because the person who died was God) and that the man Jesus created the world (because the person who created was the eternal Son).
3. **The Active and Passive Obedience:** Christ's work includes both His perfect obedience to the law (active obedience) and His suffering the penalty for sin (passive obedience). Both aspects of His work were necessary for our salvation.
4. **The Necessity of Both Natures:** Only as God could Christ pay the infinite price required for sin; only as man could He serve as a suitable substitute for humanity. The incarnation was not optional but necessary for salvation.

Practical Implications of the Incarnation

The incarnation has profound implications for Christian living and ministry:

God's Identification with Humanity: The incarnation demonstrates that God understands human experience from the inside. Jesus experienced hunger, thirst, fatigue, sorrow, and temptation (though without sin). This means that we can approach Him with confidence, knowing that He sympathizes with our weaknesses (Hebrews 4:15).

The Dignity of Human Nature: The fact that the Son of God took on human nature demonstrates the inherent dignity and value of humanity. Every human being is created in God's image and is therefore worthy of respect and care.

The Importance of the Physical World: The incarnation affirms that the physical world is good and that God is concerned with our material as well as spiritual needs. Christianity is not a purely spiritual religion that despises the body or the material world.

The Model for Humility: Philippians 2:5-11 presents the incarnation as the supreme example of humility and self-sacrifice. Just as Christ "emptied himself" and took on the form of a servant, so believers should be willing to humble themselves for the sake of others.

The Hope of Glorification: The incarnation is not temporary but permanent. The risen and ascended Christ retains His human nature, which means that humanity has been permanently united to deity. This gives us hope that we too will be glorified and will share in Christ's divine nature (2 Peter 1:4).

Reflection Questions

1. How does the virgin birth demonstrate both God's power and His grace?
2. What can we learn from Mary's response to the angel's announcement about trusting God's will even when we don't understand His plans?
3. How do the different emphases in Matthew's and Luke's birth narratives complement each other in presenting Jesus as both King and Savior?
4. Why is the doctrine of the incarnation essential to the Christian faith? What would be lost if Jesus were only divine or only human?
5. How should the truth of the incarnation affect the way we treat other people and view the physical world?

Key Terms

Incarnation: The doctrine that the eternal Son of God took on human nature while retaining His divine nature.

Virgin Birth: The doctrine that Jesus was conceived in Mary's womb by the miraculous power of the Holy Spirit without a human father.

Immanuel: A Hebrew name meaning "God with us," applied to Jesus in Matthew 1:23.

Hypostatic Union: The theological term for the union of divine and human natures in the one person of Jesus Christ.

Chalcedonian Definition: The orthodox formulation of Christology established at the Council of Chalcedon in 451 AD.

Active Obedience: Christ's perfect obedience to God's law on behalf of His people.

Passive Obedience: Christ's suffering the penalty for sin on behalf of His people.

Practical Application

The incarnation reminds us that God has not remained distant from human suffering but has entered into it personally. When we face difficulties, disappointments, or temptations, we can remember that Jesus has experienced these things and understands our struggles.

The incarnation also calls us to follow Christ's example of humility and self-sacrifice. Just as He left the glory of heaven to serve others, we should be willing to set aside our own comfort and convenience to serve those in need.

Finally, the incarnation gives us hope for the future. Because Jesus has united humanity to deity, we can look forward to our own glorification when we will be transformed into His likeness and share in His divine nature forever.

Chapter 5: The Preparation of Jesus - Baptism and Temptation

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Explain the significance of Jesus' baptism by John the Baptist
- Understand how the Trinity is revealed at Jesus' baptism
- Analyze the three temptations of Jesus in the wilderness
- Appreciate how Jesus' victory over temptation qualifies Him as our Savior
- Apply lessons from Jesus' temptation to your own spiritual battles

Scripture Foundation

"And when Jesus was baptized, immediately he went up from the water, and behold, the heavens were opened to him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and coming to rest on him; and behold, a voice from heaven said, 'This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased.'" (Matthew 3:16-17, ESV)

Memory Verse

"Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil" (Matthew 4:1, ESV)

Introduction: Preparing for Ministry

Before Jesus began His public ministry, He underwent two crucial experiences that prepared Him for the work ahead: His baptism by John the Baptist and His temptation in the wilderness. These events mark the transition from Jesus' private life in Nazareth to His public ministry throughout Palestine.

The baptism reveals Jesus' identification with sinful humanity and His anointing by the Holy Spirit for ministry. The temptation demonstrates His qualification as the sinless Savior who succeeded where Adam failed. Together, these events establish Jesus' credentials as the promised Messiah and the perfect substitute for sinners.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, these events illustrate key theological truths: the Trinity working in perfect harmony, the reality of spiritual warfare, the necessity of Christ's sinlessness, and the importance of Scripture in overcoming temptation. As we study these foundational events, we will see how they prepare Jesus for His redemptive mission and provide examples for our own spiritual journey.

The Ministry of John the Baptist

Before examining Jesus' baptism, we must understand the ministry of John the Baptist, who prepared the way for Christ's coming and administered His baptism.

John's Background and Calling: John was the son of Zechariah, a priest, and Elizabeth, a relative of Mary. His birth was miraculous, announced by the angel Gabriel to his aged parents (Luke 1:5-25, 57-80). From birth, John was set apart for a special ministry as the forerunner of the Messiah.

John's lifestyle reflected his prophetic calling. He lived in the wilderness, wore clothing of camel's hair with a leather belt, and ate locusts and wild honey (Matthew 3:4). This austere lifestyle echoed that of Elijah and demonstrated John's separation from the corrupt religious establishment of his day.

John's Message: John's preaching centered on repentance in preparation for the coming kingdom of heaven. His message was both negative and positive: negative in its call to turn from sin, positive in its promise of the coming Messiah.

The core of John's message was: "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matthew 3:2). This call to repentance was not merely emotional but involved a fundamental change of mind and heart that resulted in changed behavior. John demanded "fruit in keeping with repentance" (Matthew 3:8), demonstrating that true repentance produces visible results.

John also proclaimed the coming of one who was "mightier" than himself, one whose "sandals I am not worthy to carry" (Matthew 3:11). This greater one would baptize "with the Holy Spirit and fire" and would thoroughly purge His threshing floor (Matthew 3:11-12).

John's Baptism: John's baptism was a symbolic act that represented cleansing from sin and commitment to a new way of life. Unlike later Christian baptism, John's baptism looked forward to the coming Messiah rather than backward to His accomplished work.

The baptism took place in the Jordan River, where candidates publicly confessed their sins and submitted to immersion as a sign of their repentance. This public act demonstrated their willingness to break with their past and prepare for the coming kingdom.

John's baptism was so central to his ministry that he became known as "John the Baptist" or "John the Baptizer." His baptism prepared people for the Messiah's coming by creating a community of repentant believers who were ready to receive Jesus when He appeared.

The Baptism of Jesus

When Jesus came to John for baptism, it created a theological problem that John immediately recognized. If baptism was for sinners who needed to repent, why would the sinless Son of God seek baptism?

John's Initial Reluctance: Matthew records that John tried to prevent Jesus from being baptized, saying, "I need to be baptized by you, and do you come to me?" (Matthew 3:14). John recognized Jesus' superiority and felt unworthy to baptize Him.

This exchange demonstrates John's humility and his recognition of Jesus' true identity. Even though John was the greatest of the prophets (Matthew 11:11), he acknowledged his inferiority to Jesus and his need for what only Jesus could provide.

Jesus' Response: Jesus' reply to John reveals the purpose of His baptism: "Let it be so now, for thus it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness" (Matthew 3:15). This statement indicates that Jesus' baptism was necessary to "fulfill all righteousness"—to complete all that God required.

Several interpretations have been offered for what Jesus meant by "fulfilling all righteousness":

1. **Identification with Sinners:** Jesus' baptism demonstrated His identification with sinful humanity. Though He had no sin of His own, He took His place among sinners as their representative and substitute.
2. **Obedience to God's Will:** Jesus' baptism was an act of obedience to His Father's will. Just as He was obedient in all other aspects of His life, He was obedient in submitting to baptism.

3. **Inauguration of Ministry:** Jesus' baptism marked the beginning of His public ministry and His anointing by the Holy Spirit for the work ahead.
4. **Prophetic Symbolism:** Jesus' baptism symbolically anticipated His death and resurrection. Just as He went down into the water and came up again, so He would go down into death and rise again for our salvation.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, Jesus' baptism demonstrates His perfect obedience to the Father's will and His identification with the people He came to save. It also establishes the pattern for Christian baptism as an act of obedience and public identification with Christ.

The Trinitarian Revelation: The baptism of Jesus provides one of the clearest revelations of the Trinity in the New Testament. All three persons of the Godhead are present and active:

1. **The Son:** Jesus is baptized and receives the Father's approval
2. **The Holy Spirit:** Descends like a dove and rests upon Jesus
3. **The Father:** Speaks from heaven, declaring His pleasure in His Son

This Trinitarian revelation demonstrates the unity and diversity within the Godhead. The three persons are distinct (the Father speaks, the Spirit descends, the Son is baptized) yet united in purpose and essence.

The dove-like appearance of the Spirit recalls the Spirit's hovering over the waters at creation (Genesis 1:2) and symbolizes the new creation that Jesus will inaugurate. The Spirit's anointing of Jesus fulfills the Old Testament pattern of anointing prophets, priests, and kings for their ministries.

The Father's Declaration: The voice from heaven declares, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased" (Matthew 3:17). This declaration combines elements from Psalm 2:7 ("You are my Son") and Isaiah 42:1 ("my chosen, in whom my soul delights"), identifying Jesus as both the royal Messiah and the suffering Servant.

The Father's pleasure in His Son is not based on anything Jesus had done publicly (since this was the beginning of His ministry) but on His eternal relationship with the Father and His perfect obedience throughout His life.

The Temptation in the Wilderness

Immediately after His baptism, Jesus was "led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil" (Matthew 4:1). This temptation was not an accident but a necessary part of Jesus' preparation for ministry.

The Setting: The wilderness where Jesus was tempted was likely the Judean wilderness west of the Jordan River, a desolate area of rocky hills and deep ravines. This harsh environment provided an appropriate setting for spiritual warfare and testing.

Jesus fasted for forty days and nights, echoing Moses' forty-day fast on Mount Sinai (Exodus 34:28) and Elijah's forty-day journey to Mount Horeb (1 Kings 19:8). The number forty often represents a period of testing or preparation in Scripture.

The Nature of Temptation: It is crucial to understand that Jesus' temptation was real, not merely apparent. The writer of Hebrews affirms that Jesus "was in every respect tempted as we are, yet without sin" (Hebrews 4:15). Jesus experienced genuine temptation but never yielded to it.

The temptation came from Satan himself, not merely from Jesus' human nature or external circumstances. This was a direct assault by the enemy of souls against the Son of God, representing the cosmic conflict between good and evil.

The Three Temptations: Matthew and Luke record three specific temptations, each targeting a different aspect of human nature and Jesus' messianic mission.

First Temptation: The Lust of the Flesh (Matthew 4:2-4) After forty days of fasting, Jesus was hungry, and Satan tempted Him to turn stones into bread. This temptation appealed to Jesus' physical needs and challenged Him to use His divine power for personal comfort rather than for His Father's glory.

Satan's challenge—"If you are the Son of God"—was not a question about Jesus' identity but a temptation to prove His identity through an inappropriate use of power. The temptation was to act independently of the Father's will and to prioritize physical needs over spiritual obedience.

Jesus' response quotes Deuteronomy 8:3: "Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God." This response demonstrates that spiritual nourishment is more important than physical food and that obedience to God's word takes priority over personal comfort.

Second Temptation: The Pride of Life (Matthew 4:5-7) Satan took Jesus to the pinnacle of the temple and challenged Him to throw Himself down, quoting Psalm 91:11-12 about God's protection. This temptation appealed to pride and the desire for spectacular signs.

This temptation was particularly subtle because Satan quoted Scripture, demonstrating that even biblical truth can be misused when taken out of context or applied inappropriately. Satan challenged Jesus to force the Father to act by putting Himself in unnecessary danger.

Jesus' response quotes Deuteronomy 6:16: "You shall not put the Lord your God to the test." This demonstrates that we should not presume upon God's protection by acting foolishly or by demanding that He prove His care for us through spectacular interventions.

Third Temptation: The Lust of the Eyes (Matthew 4:8-10) Satan showed Jesus all the kingdoms of the world and offered to give them to Him if He would worship Satan. This temptation offered Jesus a shortcut to His messianic kingdom without the suffering of the cross.

This was perhaps the most serious temptation because it offered Jesus what He had legitimately come to claim—dominion over the earth—but through illegitimate means. Satan was offering Jesus His inheritance without the cross, His crown without the suffering.

Jesus' response is immediate and decisive: "Be gone, Satan! For it is written, 'You shall worship the Lord your God and him only shall you serve'" (Matthew 4:10, quoting Deuteronomy 6:13). Jesus refuses to compromise His mission or to achieve God's purposes through Satan's methods.

The Significance of Jesus' Victory

Jesus' victory over temptation has profound theological and practical significance for believers.

Qualification as Savior: Jesus' sinlessness, demonstrated through His victory over temptation, qualifies Him to serve as our Savior. Only a sinless substitute could pay the penalty for sin and provide the righteousness that God requires.

The parallel between Jesus and Adam is particularly significant. Where Adam failed in a perfect environment with every advantage, Jesus succeeded in a hostile environment while weakened by fasting. Jesus is the "last Adam" who succeeded where the first Adam failed (1 Corinthians 15:45).

Example for Believers: Jesus' method of overcoming temptation provides a model for believers. He relied on Scripture, prayer, and obedience to the Father's will rather than on His divine power. This demonstrates that the same resources available to Jesus are available to us.

Each of Jesus' responses to temptation came from the book of Deuteronomy, showing the importance of knowing and applying Scripture in spiritual warfare. The "sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God" (Ephesians 6:17) is our primary weapon against temptation.

Sympathetic High Priest: Because Jesus was tempted in every way as we are, He can sympathize with our weaknesses and provide help in time of need (Hebrews 4:15-16). His victory over temptation does not make Him unsympathetic to our struggles but rather qualifies Him to help us in our battles.

Defeat of Satan: Jesus' victory in the wilderness was the first of many defeats He would inflict upon Satan. The cross would be the decisive victory, but the temptation demonstrated that Satan had no power over the sinless Son of God.

Practical Applications for Spiritual Warfare

Jesus' temptation provides practical guidance for believers facing their own spiritual battles:

Know Scripture: Jesus defeated each temptation by quoting appropriate Scripture. Believers must be diligent in studying and memorizing God's word so that it is available in times of testing.

Recognize Satan's Tactics: Satan's temptations often appeal to legitimate needs (hunger) or desires (power) but seek to fulfill them through illegitimate means. Believers must learn to distinguish between God's provision and Satan's counterfeits.

Don't Negotiate with Temptation: Jesus did not enter into extended dialogue with Satan but immediately responded with Scripture and decisive action. Believers should not linger in tempting situations or try to reason with temptation.

Rely on God's Strength: Jesus relied on the Father's strength rather than His own divine power, demonstrating that victory over temptation comes through dependence on God rather than human effort.

Expect Spiritual Warfare: The fact that Jesus was tempted immediately after His baptism and anointing demonstrates that spiritual attack often follows spiritual blessing. Believers should be prepared for increased temptation during times of spiritual growth.

Reflection Questions

1. Why was it necessary for Jesus to be baptized if He had no sin to confess?
2. How does the Trinitarian revelation at Jesus' baptism deepen your understanding of God's nature?
3. What can we learn from Jesus' method of overcoming temptation about our own spiritual battles?
4. How does Jesus' victory over temptation encourage you when you face difficult circumstances or moral choices?
5. Why is it significant that Jesus was tempted "in every respect" as we are, yet without sin?

Key Terms

Baptism: A symbolic act of immersion in water representing cleansing from sin and identification with Christ.

Trinity: The doctrine that God exists as three persons (Father, Son, Holy Spirit) in one essence.

Temptation: An enticement to sin or to act contrary to God's will.

Sinlessness: The doctrine that Jesus never committed sin in thought, word, or deed.

Spiritual Warfare: The ongoing conflict between good and evil, God and Satan, in the spiritual realm.

Fasting: Abstaining from food for spiritual purposes such as prayer, seeking God's will, or spiritual discipline.

Practical Application

Jesus' baptism and temptation remind us that following God often involves both public identification with His people and private spiritual battles. Just as Jesus publicly identified with sinners through baptism and privately battled Satan in the wilderness, we must be willing both to stand publicly for Christ and to fight private battles against sin and temptation.

The resources that enabled Jesus to overcome temptation—Scripture, prayer, and dependence on the Father—are available to us as well. We can face our own temptations with confidence, knowing that our Savior has gone before us and provides both an example to follow and the strength to overcome.

Most importantly, Jesus' victory over temptation assures us that we have a Savior who understands our struggles and is able to help us in our time of need. When we fail, we can turn to Him for forgiveness; when we face temptation, we can turn to Him for strength.

Chapter 6: The Calling of the Twelve Disciples

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand Jesus' method of selecting and training disciples

- Identify the twelve apostles and their backgrounds
- Explain the cost and privileges of discipleship
- Apply principles of discipleship to your own spiritual growth

Scripture Foundation

"And he called to him his twelve disciples and gave them authority over unclean spirits, to cast them out, and to heal every disease and every affliction." (Matthew 10:1, ESV)

Memory Verse

"Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men" (Matthew 4:19, ESV)

Introduction: Jesus' Method of Ministry

One of the most significant aspects of Jesus' ministry was His calling and training of twelve disciples who would become the foundation of the early church. Rather than working alone or establishing an institution, Jesus invested His life in a small group of men who would carry on His mission after His ascension.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, Jesus' calling of the disciples demonstrates God's sovereignty in salvation and His use of ordinary people to accomplish extraordinary purposes. The disciples were not chosen because of their qualifications but because of God's grace, illustrating the doctrine of unconditional election.

The Call to Discipleship

The First Disciples (Matthew 4:18-22): Jesus' first disciples were fishermen working on the Sea of Galilee. Simon Peter and Andrew were casting nets when Jesus called them with the simple command, "Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men." James and John were mending nets with their father Zebedee when Jesus called them.

The immediate response of these men—they "immediately left their nets and followed him"—demonstrates the compelling power of Jesus' call. This was not merely human persuasion but divine calling that created faith and obedience.

The Call of Matthew (Matthew 9:9-13): The calling of Matthew (Levi) the tax collector illustrates Jesus' grace in calling the despised and rejected. Tax collectors were considered traitors by their fellow Jews and were excluded from religious fellowship.

Jesus' willingness to eat with "tax collectors and sinners" scandalized the Pharisees but demonstrated the inclusive nature of His kingdom. His response—"I came not to call the righteous, but sinners"—reveals the purpose of His mission.

The Twelve Apostles

Jesus chose twelve men to be His closest followers and representatives. The number twelve was significant, corresponding to the twelve tribes of Israel and symbolizing the restoration of God's people.

Simon Peter: A fisherman from Bethsaida, Peter was impulsive and often spoke before thinking. Despite his failures (including denying Jesus), he became the leader of the apostles and the early church.

Andrew: Peter's brother, also a fisherman. Andrew is often mentioned as bringing others to Jesus, including his brother Peter and the boy with loaves and fishes.

James and John: Sons of Zebedee, nicknamed "Sons of Thunder" for their fiery temperament. John became known as "the disciple whom Jesus loved" and wrote the fourth Gospel.

Philip and Bartholomew (Nathanael): Philip brought Nathanael to Jesus, demonstrating the evangelistic heart of true discipleship.

Matthew (Levi): The tax collector who left his lucrative career to follow Jesus and later wrote the first Gospel.

Thomas: Known for his doubts but also for his eventual strong faith, declaring Jesus "My Lord and my God!"

James the Less and Thaddeus (Judas, not Iscariot): Less prominent disciples about whom little is known.

Simon the Zealot: A former revolutionary who learned to serve in God's kingdom rather than fight for earthly kingdoms.

Judas Iscariot: The treasurer who betrayed Jesus for thirty pieces of silver, fulfilling Scripture but demonstrating the tragedy of false discipleship.

The Cost of Discipleship

Jesus was clear about the demands of following Him:

Leaving Everything: The disciples left their occupations, families, and security to follow Jesus. True discipleship requires putting Christ above all earthly attachments.

Taking Up the Cross: Jesus told His disciples, "If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me" (Matthew 16:24). Discipleship involves self-denial and willingness to suffer for Christ.

Counting the Cost: Jesus warned potential followers to count the cost before committing to discipleship (Luke 14:25-33). Following Christ is not a casual decision but a life-transforming commitment.

The Privileges of Discipleship

Despite its costs, discipleship brings tremendous privileges:

Intimate Fellowship with Jesus: The disciples enjoyed close personal relationship with the Son of God, witnessing His miracles and hearing His teachings.

Authority and Power: Jesus gave His disciples authority to cast out demons and heal diseases, demonstrating that He shares His power with His followers.

Eternal Rewards: Jesus promised that those who follow Him will receive eternal life and will reign with Him in His kingdom.

Reflection Questions

1. What can we learn from Jesus' method of calling ordinary people to be His disciples?
2. How does the diversity of the twelve apostles encourage us about God's use of different personalities and backgrounds?
3. What does it mean to "count the cost" of discipleship in today's world?
4. How can we apply Jesus' model of investing in a few people to our own ministry and relationships?

Key Terms

Disciple: A learner or follower who commits to learning from and imitating a teacher. **Apostle:** One who is sent as a representative or messenger. **Discipleship:** The process of following and learning from Jesus Christ.

Chapter 7: Jesus' Early Miracles - Demonstrating Divine Authority

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Categorize the different types of miracles Jesus performed
- Understand the purpose and significance of Jesus' miraculous works
- Explain how miracles demonstrate Jesus' divine authority
- Apply lessons from Jesus' miracles to contemporary faith and ministry

Scripture Foundation

"And he went throughout all Galilee, teaching in their synagogues and proclaiming the gospel of the kingdom and healing every disease and every affliction among the people." (Matthew 4:23, ESV)

Memory Verse

"But that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins"—he said to the paralytic—"Rise, pick up your bed and go home" (Matthew 9:6, ESV)

Introduction: Signs of the Kingdom

Jesus' miracles were not merely displays of supernatural power but signs that pointed to His identity as the Messiah and the arrival of God's kingdom. Each miracle demonstrated Jesus' authority over different aspects of the fallen creation: disease, demons, nature, and death.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, Jesus' miracles authenticate His divine nature and messianic mission while demonstrating God's compassion for human suffering. They also prefigure the ultimate restoration that will come when Christ returns to establish His eternal kingdom.

Categories of Miracles

Healing Miracles: Jesus healed every kind of disease and affliction, demonstrating His power over the effects of sin in the human body. Notable healings include:

- The nobleman's son (John 4:46-54)
- Peter's mother-in-law (Matthew 8:14-15)
- The paralytic (Matthew 9:1-8)
- The woman with bleeding (Matthew 9:20-22)
- Two blind men (Matthew 9:27-31)

Exorcisms: Jesus cast out demons, demonstrating His authority over Satan and the spiritual realm. These miracles showed that the kingdom of God was breaking into Satan's domain.

Nature Miracles: Jesus demonstrated His authority over the natural world through miracles such as:

- Turning water into wine (John 2:1-11)
- Calming the storm (Matthew 8:23-27)
- Feeding the 5,000 (Matthew 14:13-21)
- Walking on water (Matthew 14:22-33)

Resurrection Miracles: Jesus raised the dead, demonstrating His power over death itself and prefiguring His own resurrection.

The Purpose of Miracles

Authentication: Miracles authenticated Jesus' claims about His identity and mission. They were "signs" that pointed to His divine nature and messianic calling.

Compassion: Jesus was moved with compassion for human suffering and performed miracles to relieve pain and distress.

Teaching: Miracles often accompanied and illustrated Jesus' teaching, providing object lessons about spiritual truths.

Kingdom Demonstration: Miracles showed what life will be like in God's eternal kingdom, where there will be no sickness, suffering, or death.

The Significance of Specific Miracles

The Healing of the Paralytic (Matthew 9:1-8): This miracle demonstrates Jesus' authority to forgive sins, which only God can do. The physical healing proved the reality of the spiritual healing.

The Calming of the Storm (Matthew 8:23-27): This miracle revealed Jesus' divine nature to His disciples, who asked, "What sort of man is this, that even winds and sea obey him?"

The Feeding of the 5,000 (Matthew 14:13-21): This miracle demonstrated Jesus' ability to provide for human needs and prefigured the spiritual nourishment He provides through His word and sacraments.

Faith and Miracles

Jesus often connected miracles with faith, saying to those He healed, "Your faith has made you well." This does not mean that faith causes miracles, but that faith is the means by which we receive God's gracious gifts.

The absence of faith could limit Jesus' miraculous work, as seen in His hometown of Nazareth where "he did not do many mighty works there, because of their unbelief" (Matthew 13:58).

Reflection Questions

1. How do Jesus' miracles demonstrate both His divine power and His human compassion?
2. What is the relationship between faith and miracles in Jesus' ministry?
3. How should we understand miracles in the context of God's sovereignty and human suffering?
4. What do Jesus' miracles teach us about the nature of God's kingdom?

Key Terms

Miracle: A supernatural act of God that transcends natural laws. **Sign:** A miracle that points to a spiritual truth or divine reality. **Exorcism:** The casting out of demons or evil spirits. **Faith:** Trust in God and His promises, often demonstrated through action.

Chapter 8: The Growing Opposition

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Identify the sources and reasons for opposition to Jesus
- Understand the religious and political factors that led to conflict
- Explain how opposition revealed both human sinfulness and divine grace
- Apply lessons about facing opposition in Christian life and ministry

Scripture Foundation

"Then the Pharisees went out and immediately held counsel with the Herodians against him, how to destroy him." (Mark 3:6, ESV)

Memory Verse

"If the world hates you, know that it has hated me before it hated you" (John 15:18, ESV)

Introduction: The Inevitable Conflict

As Jesus' ministry gained momentum, opposition began to mount from various quarters. Religious leaders felt threatened by His authority and popularity. Political leaders worried about potential unrest. Even some ordinary people were offended by His radical teachings and claims.

This growing opposition was not accidental but inevitable, given the fallen nature of humanity and the radical nature of Jesus' message. From a Reformed Baptist perspective, this opposition demonstrates the doctrine of total depravity—humanity's natural hostility toward God and His truth.

Sources of Opposition

The Pharisees: The Pharisees opposed Jesus primarily on religious grounds. They were offended by His claims to authority, His association with sinners, and His interpretation of the law. Key conflicts included:

- Sabbath observance (Matthew 12:1-14)
- Ritual purity (Matthew 15:1-20)
- Authority to forgive sins (Matthew 9:1-8)
- Association with tax collectors and sinners (Matthew 9:9-13)

The Sadducees: The Sadducees opposed Jesus primarily on political grounds. As the ruling religious party, they were concerned about maintaining their position and avoiding conflict with Rome.

The Scribes: The scribes, as experts in the law, felt threatened by Jesus' authoritative teaching and His criticism of their traditions.

The Herodians: This political party supported the Herodian dynasty and Roman rule. They opposed Jesus because of His messianic claims and potential threat to political stability.

The Common People: While many followed Jesus, others were offended by His demands for total commitment and His claims to divine authority.

Reasons for Opposition

Threat to Authority: Jesus' teaching and miracles challenged the authority of the established religious leadership. His claim to speak for God undermined their position as mediators between God and the people.

Challenge to Tradition: Jesus criticized many of the traditions that the religious leaders held dear, calling them "traditions of men" that made void the word of God (Mark 7:13).

Association with Sinners: Jesus' willingness to eat with tax collectors and sinners scandalized those who believed that righteousness required separation from the unclean.

Messianic Claims: Jesus' implicit and explicit claims to be the Messiah threatened both religious and political establishments.

Conviction of Sin: Jesus' perfect life and penetrating teaching convicted people of their sin, creating discomfort and resentment.

The Nature of Spiritual Opposition

The opposition to Jesus reveals important truths about the nature of spiritual conflict:

Blindness to Truth: Despite overwhelming evidence of Jesus' divine authority, His opponents refused to believe. This demonstrates the spiritual blindness that sin produces.

Hardness of Heart: Repeated exposure to truth without response leads to increasing hardness of heart. The religious leaders became more determined to oppose Jesus despite mounting evidence of His divine nature.

Coalition of Enemies: Strange alliances formed between groups that normally opposed each other (Pharisees and Herodians, Jews and Romans) in their common opposition to Jesus.

Escalating Hostility: Opposition began with criticism and questioning but escalated to plots for Jesus' destruction.

Jesus' Response to Opposition

Continued Ministry: Jesus did not allow opposition to deter Him from His mission. He continued teaching, healing, and proclaiming the kingdom of God.

Wisdom in Withdrawal: At times, Jesus withdrew from areas of intense opposition, demonstrating wisdom in avoiding unnecessary confrontation while continuing His work.

Direct Confrontation: When necessary, Jesus directly confronted His opponents, exposing their hypocrisy and false teaching.

Preparation of Disciples: Jesus used opposition as an opportunity to prepare His disciples for the persecution they would face after His departure.

Lessons for Contemporary Believers

Expect Opposition: Jesus warned His followers that they would face opposition: "If they persecuted me, they will also persecute you" (John 15:20).

Understand the Source: Opposition to the gospel often stems from spiritual blindness and hardness of heart rather than intellectual objections.

Respond with Grace: Jesus' example shows us how to respond to opposition with grace, truth, and love rather than anger or retaliation.

Trust God's Sovereignty: Even opposition serves God's purposes, as seen in how the religious leaders' rejection of Jesus led to His crucifixion and our salvation.

Reflection Questions

1. Why was opposition to Jesus inevitable given His message and claims?
2. How did Jesus' response to opposition provide a model for believers facing persecution?
3. What can we learn from the various sources of opposition about human nature and spiritual blindness?
4. How should understanding the inevitability of opposition affect our approach to evangelism and ministry?

Key Terms

Opposition: Resistance or hostility toward Jesus and His message. **Persecution:** Suffering inflicted because of one's faith or beliefs. **Spiritual Blindness:** The inability to perceive spiritual truth due to sin. **Hardness of Heart:** A condition of stubborn resistance to God's truth.

Unit 2 Review and Assessment

Unit 2 Summary: In this unit, we have studied the early life and ministry of Jesus, from His incarnation through the beginning of His public ministry. We have seen how Jesus' birth fulfilled Old Testament prophecy, how His baptism and temptation prepared Him for ministry, how He called disciples to follow Him, how His miracles demonstrated His divine authority, and how opposition began to mount against Him.

Key Concepts to Remember:

- The theological significance of the incarnation and virgin birth
- The Trinitarian revelation at Jesus' baptism
- Jesus' victory over temptation and its implications for believers
- The calling and training of the twelve disciples
- The purpose and significance of Jesus' miracles
- The sources and nature of opposition to Jesus

Scripture Memory Review:

- Isaiah 7:14 - "Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son"
- Matthew 4:1 - "Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted"
- Matthew 4:19 - "Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men"

- Matthew 9:6 - "That you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins"
- John 15:18 - "If the world hates you, know that it has hated me before it hated you"

Preparation for Unit 3: Having studied Jesus' early life and ministry, we are now ready to examine His teachings in detail. In Unit 3, we will study Jesus' parables and major discourses, including the Sermon on the Mount and the Upper Room Discourse.

UNIT 3: THE TEACHINGS OF JESUS - PARABLES AND DISCOURSES (6 Weeks)

Unit Overview

Jesus was not only a miracle worker but also the greatest teacher who ever lived. His teachings, preserved in the Gospels, reveal the nature of God's kingdom and provide guidance for Christian living. In this unit, we will examine Jesus' major teaching methods and messages, including His parables, discourses, and "I AM" statements.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, Jesus' teachings demonstrate His divine wisdom and authority while revealing the nature of salvation by grace through faith. His parables illustrate spiritual truths in memorable ways, while His discourses provide systematic instruction about the kingdom of God and the Christian life.

Chapter 9: The Sermon on the Mount - The Kingdom Ethic (Matthew 5-7)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the structure and purpose of the Sermon on the Mount
- Explain the Beatitudes and their significance for Christian character
- Analyze Jesus' teaching about law, righteousness, and discipleship
- Apply the principles of kingdom living to contemporary Christian life

Scripture Foundation

"Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." (Matthew 5:3, ESV)

Memory Verse

"But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you" (Matthew 6:33, ESV)

Introduction: The Constitution of the Kingdom

The Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5-7) is Jesus' most comprehensive teaching about the nature of His kingdom and the character of His followers. This sermon, delivered early in His ministry, establishes the ethical foundation for Christian living and reveals the radical nature of kingdom citizenship.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, the Sermon on the Mount does not teach salvation by works but describes the character and conduct that flow from salvation by grace. It shows us what redeemed people look like when they are being transformed by the Holy Spirit.

The Beatitudes (Matthew 5:3-12)

The Beatitudes describe the character traits of kingdom citizens and the blessings they receive:

Poor in Spirit: Recognizing our spiritual bankruptcy and need for God's grace **Those Who Mourn:** Grieving over sin and its effects in the world **The Meek:** Gentle strength that trusts in God rather than self **Hunger and Thirst for Righteousness:** Intense desire for God's will to be done **The Merciful:** Showing compassion to others as God has shown to us **Pure in Heart:** Single-minded devotion to God and His purposes **Peacemakers:** Working to reconcile people to God and each other **Persecuted for Righteousness:** Suffering for doing what is right

Jesus and the Law (Matthew 5:17-48)

Jesus clarified His relationship to the Old Testament law, stating that He came not to abolish but to fulfill it. He then provided six examples of how His teaching goes beyond external compliance to heart transformation:

- Murder and anger (vv. 21-26)
- Adultery and lust (vv. 27-30)
- Divorce and commitment (vv. 31-32)
- Oaths and truthfulness (vv. 33-37)
- Retaliation and love for enemies (vv. 38-48)

Spiritual Disciplines (Matthew 6:1-18)

Jesus taught about three key spiritual disciplines, warning against practicing them for human approval:

Giving: Should be done secretly, not for public recognition **Prayer:** Should be sincere communication with God, not empty repetition **Fasting:** Should be genuine spiritual discipline, not religious show

The Lord's Prayer (6:9-13) provides a model for Christian prayer, emphasizing God's glory, kingdom, and provision.

Kingdom Priorities (Matthew 6:19-34)

Jesus taught about proper priorities for kingdom citizens:

Treasure in Heaven: Investing in eternal rather than temporal things **Single Vision:** Focusing on God rather than being divided in loyalty **Trust in God's Provision:** Not worrying about material needs but trusting God's care

Practical Wisdom (Matthew 7:1-27)

The sermon concludes with practical wisdom for kingdom living:

Judging Others: Avoiding hypocritical judgment while exercising discernment **Prayer and Persistence:** Confidence in God's willingness to answer prayer **The Golden Rule:** Treating others as we want to be treated **The Narrow Gate:** The exclusive nature of salvation through Christ **False Prophets:** Recognizing false teachers by their fruits **True Discipleship:** Obedience to Christ's words, not mere profession

Reformed Baptist Interpretation

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, the Sermon on the Mount:

- Reveals the impossibility of earning salvation through good works
- Describes the character that God produces in His people through grace
- Shows the need for Christ's perfect righteousness to be imputed to us
- Provides guidance for Christian living empowered by the Holy Spirit

Reflection Questions

1. How do the Beatitudes challenge worldly values and priorities?
2. What does Jesus' teaching about the law reveal about the nature of true righteousness?
3. How can we practice the spiritual disciplines without falling into hypocrisy?

4. What does it mean to "seek first the kingdom of God" in practical terms?
-

Chapter 10: The Parables of the Kingdom

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand Jesus' use of parables as a teaching method
- Interpret key parables about the kingdom of heaven
- Apply parable principles to contemporary Christian life
- Explain how parables reveal and conceal spiritual truth

Scripture Foundation

"And he said to them, 'To you has been given the secret of the kingdom of God, but for those outside everything is in parables.'" (Mark 4:11, ESV)

Memory Verse

"The kingdom of heaven is like a grain of mustard seed that a man took and sowed in his field" (Matthew 13:31, ESV)

Introduction: Teaching in Parables

Jesus frequently used parables—earthly stories with heavenly meanings—to teach about the kingdom of God. These simple stories, drawn from everyday life, contained profound spiritual truths that challenged listeners to think deeply about God's kingdom and their response to it.

The Purpose of Parables

Parables served multiple purposes in Jesus' teaching:

Revelation: For those with faith, parables revealed spiritual truths in memorable and compelling ways **Concealment:** For those who rejected Jesus, parables concealed truth and confirmed their spiritual blindness **Judgment:** Parables separated true disciples from mere curiosity seekers **Memorability:** Stories are easier to remember than abstract concepts

Key Kingdom Parables

The Sower (Matthew 13:3-23): Illustrates different responses to the gospel message and the importance of good soil (receptive hearts) for spiritual growth.

The Wheat and Tares (Matthew 13:24-30, 36-43): Teaches that good and evil will coexist until the final judgment, when God will separate them.

The Mustard Seed (Matthew 13:31-32): Shows how God's kingdom starts small but grows to great size and influence.

The Hidden Treasure and Pearl (Matthew 13:44-46): Illustrates the supreme value of the kingdom and the joy of those who find it.

The Unforgiving Servant (Matthew 18:21-35): Teaches that those who have received God's forgiveness must extend forgiveness to others.

The Workers in the Vineyard (Matthew 20:1-16): Reveals God's grace in giving equal rewards regardless of when people enter His service.

The Prodigal Son (Luke 15:11-32): Demonstrates God's love for sinners and His joy when they repent and return to Him.

The Good Samaritan (Luke 10:25-37): Defines true neighborliness and challenges prejudice and indifference.

Principles of Parable Interpretation

Find the Main Point: Each parable typically teaches one central truth **Consider the Context:** Understanding the historical and literary context helps interpretation **Look for Jesus:** Many parables point to Christ and His work of salvation **Apply Carefully:** Apply the main point without forcing details to have symbolic meaning

Reformed Baptist Understanding

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, the parables:

- Illustrate salvation by grace alone through faith alone
- Demonstrate God's sovereignty in salvation and judgment
- Reveal the nature of true discipleship and Christian living
- Show the progressive nature of sanctification

Reflection Questions

1. Why did Jesus choose to teach in parables rather than direct statements?
2. How do the parables reveal both God's grace and His justice?
3. Which parable speaks most powerfully to your current spiritual condition?
4. How can we apply parable principles to our evangelism and discipleship?

Chapter 11: The "I AM" Statements of Jesus (John's Gospel)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Identify and explain the seven "I AM" statements in John's Gospel
- Understand the connection between these statements and God's name revealed to Moses
- Explain how these statements reveal Jesus' divine nature and mission
- Apply the truths revealed in these statements to Christian living

Scripture Foundation

"Jesus said to them, 'Truly, truly, I say to you, before Abraham was, I am.'" (John 8:58, ESV)

Memory Verse

"Jesus said to him, 'I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me'" (John 14:6, ESV)

Introduction: Divine Self-Revelation

In John's Gospel, Jesus makes seven profound "I AM" statements that reveal His divine nature and mission. These statements echo God's revelation of His name to Moses at the burning bush (Exodus 3:14) and demonstrate Jesus' claim to deity.

The Seven "I AM" Statements

"I am the bread of life" (John 6:35): Jesus satisfies spiritual hunger and provides eternal life. Just as bread sustains physical life, Jesus sustains spiritual life.

"I am the light of the world" (John 8:12): Jesus illuminates spiritual darkness and guides people to truth. He reveals God's character and exposes sin.

"I am the door" (John 10:7, 9): Jesus is the only way into God's fold. He provides access to the Father and security for His sheep.

"I am the good shepherd" (John 10:11, 14): Jesus cares for His people with sacrificial love, even laying down His life for them. He knows His sheep and they know Him.

"I am the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25): Jesus has power over death and gives eternal life to all who believe in Him.

"I am the way, and the truth, and the life" (John 14:6): Jesus is the exclusive path to God, the embodiment of truth, and the source of spiritual life.

"I am the true vine" (John 15:1, 5): Jesus is the source of spiritual life and fruitfulness. Believers must remain connected to Him to bear fruit.

The Significance of "I AM"

The phrase "I AM" (Greek: ego eimi) connects Jesus with Yahweh, the covenant name of God revealed to Moses. When Jesus said, "Before Abraham was, I am" (John 8:58), the Jews understood His claim to deity and tried to stone Him for blasphemy.

Reformed Baptist Understanding

These statements demonstrate:

- Jesus' full deity and equality with the Father
- The exclusivity of salvation through Christ alone
- The believer's complete dependence on Christ for spiritual life
- The intimate relationship between Christ and His people

Reflection Questions

1. How do the "I AM" statements reveal both Jesus' divine nature and His care for humanity?
 2. What does it mean that Jesus is "the way, the truth, and the life" in our pluralistic culture?
 3. How does understanding Jesus as the "good shepherd" comfort and challenge believers?
 4. What does it mean to "abide in the vine" in practical Christian living?
-

Chapter 12: Miracles and Their Meaning

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the symbolic significance of Jesus' miracles
- Explain how miracles authenticate Jesus' divine claims

- Analyze the relationship between faith and miraculous works
- Apply lessons from Jesus' miracles to contemporary Christian life

Scripture Foundation

"Now Jesus did many other signs in the presence of the disciples, which are not written in this book; but these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name." (John 20:30-31, ESV)

Memory Verse

"And he said to her, 'Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace, and be healed of your disease'" (Mark 5:34, ESV)

Introduction: Signs and Wonders

Jesus' miracles were not random displays of power but carefully chosen signs that revealed His identity and mission. Each miracle demonstrated His authority over different aspects of the fallen creation and pointed to the ultimate restoration He would accomplish.

Categories and Meanings

Healing Miracles: Demonstrated Jesus' power over disease and His compassion for human suffering. They pointed to the ultimate healing from sin and its effects.

Nature Miracles: Showed Jesus' authority over creation as its divine Creator. They revealed His power to provide for human needs and control natural forces.

Exorcisms: Demonstrated Jesus' victory over Satan and evil spirits. They showed that God's kingdom was breaking into Satan's domain.

Resurrections: Revealed Jesus' power over death itself and prefigured His own resurrection and the believer's future resurrection.

The Role of Faith

Faith played a crucial role in Jesus' miraculous ministry:

- Faith was often the means by which people received healing
- Lack of faith could limit Jesus' miraculous work
- Faith demonstrated trust in Jesus' power and willingness to help
- Miracles often strengthened and confirmed faith

Symbolic Significance

Many miracles had symbolic meaning beyond their immediate physical effects:

- Healing the blind symbolized spiritual enlightenment
- Cleansing lepers represented purification from sin
- Feeding multitudes pointed to spiritual nourishment
- Calming storms illustrated peace with God

Contemporary Application

While we may not see the same miraculous works today, Jesus' miracles teach us:

- God's compassion for human suffering
- The importance of faith in our relationship with God
- The reality of spiritual warfare and Christ's victory
- The hope of ultimate restoration in God's kingdom

Reflection Questions

1. How do Jesus' miracles reveal both His divine power and human compassion?
 2. What is the relationship between faith and miracles in Jesus' ministry?
 3. How should we understand the symbolic meaning of Jesus' miraculous works?
 4. What do Jesus' miracles teach us about God's ultimate plan for creation?
-

Chapter 13: The Upper Room Discourse (John 13-17)

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the context and significance of Jesus' final teaching to His disciples
- Explain Jesus' teaching about the Holy Spirit's ministry
- Analyze Jesus' high priestly prayer and its implications
- Apply principles of Christian unity and service to contemporary church life

Scripture Foundation

"A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another." (John 13:34, ESV)

Memory Verse

"I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing" (John 15:5, ESV)

Introduction: Final Instructions

On the night before His crucifixion, Jesus gathered with His disciples in an upper room for the Passover meal. During this intimate time, He gave His most detailed teaching about the Christian life, the Holy Spirit's ministry, and His relationship with the Father.

The Washing of Feet (John 13:1-20)

Jesus demonstrated servant leadership by washing His disciples' feet, a task normally performed by servants. This act taught:

- The importance of humble service
- The need for spiritual cleansing
- The example leaders should follow
- The blessing of serving others

The New Commandment (John 13:31-35)

Jesus gave His disciples a "new commandment" to love one another as He had loved them. This love would be the distinguishing mark of His followers and their witness to the world.

Comfort for Troubled Hearts (John 14:1-31)

Jesus comforted His disciples with promises:

- He was going to prepare a place for them
- He would come again to receive them
- He is the only way to the Father
- The Holy Spirit would come as their Helper

The Vine and Branches (John 15:1-17)

Jesus used the metaphor of a vine and branches to teach about:

- The believer's dependence on Christ for spiritual life
- The necessity of abiding in Christ to bear fruit
- The Father's pruning work in believers' lives
- The importance of obedience and love

The World's Hatred (John 15:18-16:4)

Jesus warned His disciples that the world would hate them because:

- They belonged to Him rather than the world
- The world hated Him first
- Persecution would come from religious authorities
- Their witness would convict the world of sin

The Holy Spirit's Ministry (John 16:5-15)

Jesus taught about the Holy Spirit's work:

- Convicting the world of sin, righteousness, and judgment
- Guiding believers into all truth
- Glorifying Christ by revealing His truth
- Comforting and helping believers

The High Priestly Prayer (John 17)

Jesus' prayer for His disciples and all believers includes:

- Prayer for His own glorification (vv. 1-5)
- Prayer for His disciples' protection and sanctification (vv. 6-19)
- Prayer for all believers' unity and witness (vv. 20-26)

Reformed Baptist Understanding

The Upper Room Discourse reveals:

- The Trinity's work in salvation and sanctification
- The believer's security in Christ's intercession
- The importance of church unity and love
- The Holy Spirit's role in Christian growth

Reflection Questions

1. How does Jesus' washing of the disciples' feet challenge our understanding of leadership?
 2. What does it mean to "abide in Christ" in practical terms?
 3. How should Jesus' teaching about the world's hatred prepare us for opposition?
 4. What can we learn from Jesus' high priestly prayer about His priorities for His people?
-

Chapter 14: Final Teachings and Warnings

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand Jesus' teaching about the end times and His second coming
- Explain the parables of readiness and their application
- Analyze Jesus' warnings about false teachers and spiritual deception
- Apply principles of watchfulness and faithfulness to Christian living

Scripture Foundation

"Therefore, stay awake, for you do not know on what day your Lord is coming."
(Matthew 24:42, ESV)

Memory Verse

"Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away" (Matthew 24:35, ESV)

Introduction: Preparing for the Future

As Jesus' earthly ministry drew to a close, He spent considerable time preparing His disciples for the future. He taught them about His second coming, warned them about false teachers, and emphasized the importance of faithfulness and readiness.

The Olivet Discourse (Matthew 24-25)

Jesus' teaching about the end times includes:

Signs of the End: Wars, famines, earthquakes, persecution, and false prophets would precede His return
The Destruction of Jerusalem: Jesus predicted the temple's destruction, fulfilled in 70 AD
The Second Coming: Jesus will return visibly and gloriously to establish His kingdom
The Need for Watchfulness: Since the timing is unknown, believers must always be ready

Parables of Readiness

The Ten Virgins (Matthew 25:1-13): Emphasizes the need for spiritual preparation and the danger of presumption

The Talents (Matthew 25:14-30): Teaches faithful stewardship of God's gifts and the accountability of servants

The Sheep and Goats (Matthew 25:31-46): Describes the final judgment based on how people treated Christ's followers

Warnings About False Teachers

Jesus warned about:

- False prophets who would deceive many
- False messiahs who would claim to be Christ
- Teachers who would lead people astray
- The importance of testing all teaching by Scripture

The Great Commission (Matthew 28:18-20)

Jesus' final command to His disciples was to:

- Make disciples of all nations
- Baptize believers in the name of the Trinity
- Teach obedience to His commands
- Trust in His presence and authority

Reformed Baptist Perspective

From a Reformed Baptist viewpoint, these teachings emphasize:

- The certainty of Christ's return and final judgment
- The importance of perseverance in faith and good works
- The sovereignty of God in salvation and history
- The responsibility of believers to share the gospel

Reflection Questions

1. How should the certainty of Christ's return affect our daily priorities and decisions?
2. What do the parables of readiness teach us about spiritual preparation?
3. How can we discern false teaching and protect ourselves from deception?
4. What does faithful stewardship look like in our contemporary context?

Unit 3 Review and Assessment

Unit 3 Summary: In this unit, we have examined Jesus' major teachings, including the Sermon on the Mount, His parables about the kingdom, His "I AM" statements, the significance of His miracles, the Upper Room Discourse, and His final warnings and commission. These teachings reveal the nature of God's kingdom and provide guidance for Christian living.

Key Concepts to Remember:

- The Beatitudes and kingdom ethics
- The purpose and interpretation of parables
- Jesus' divine claims in the "I AM" statements
- The symbolic significance of miracles
- The Holy Spirit's ministry and Christian unity
- The importance of readiness for Christ's return

Scripture Memory Review:

- Matthew 6:33 - "Seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness"
- Matthew 13:31 - "The kingdom of heaven is like a grain of mustard seed"
- John 14:6 - "I am the way, and the truth, and the life"
- Mark 5:34 - "Your faith has made you well"
- John 15:5 - "I am the vine; you are the branches"
- Matthew 24:35 - "My words will not pass away"

Preparation for Unit 4: Having studied Jesus' teachings, we are now ready to examine the climax of His earthly ministry. In Unit 4, we will study Passion Week, from His triumphal entry into Jerusalem through His crucifixion and resurrection.

UNIT 4: THE CLIMAX OF THE GOSPELS - PASSION WEEK (4 Weeks)

Unit Overview

The final week of Jesus' earthly ministry represents the climax of God's redemptive plan. From His triumphal entry into Jerusalem to His resurrection from the dead, every event of Passion Week was orchestrated by divine providence to accomplish our salvation.

From a Reformed Baptist perspective, Passion Week demonstrates the sovereignty of God in salvation, the substitutionary nature of Christ's atonement, and the victory of grace over sin and death. These events are not merely historical but theological, revealing the heart of the gospel and the foundation of our faith.

Chapter 15: The Triumphal Entry and Final Week in Jerusalem

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the significance of Jesus' triumphal entry into Jerusalem
- Explain the events of the final week leading to the crucifixion
- Analyze the religious and political tensions that culminated in Jesus' arrest
- Appreciate how these events fulfilled Old Testament prophecy

Scripture Foundation

"Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion! Shout aloud, O daughter of Jerusalem! Behold, your king is coming to you; righteous and having salvation is he, humble and mounted on a donkey, on a colt, the foal of a donkey." (Zechariah 9:9, ESV)

Memory Verse

"Hosanna to the Son of David! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord! Hosanna in the highest!" (Matthew 21:9, ESV)

Introduction: The King Comes to His City

Jesus' entry into Jerusalem on Palm Sunday marked the beginning of the most significant week in human history. This event, celebrated by crowds but opposed by religious leaders, set in motion the events that would lead to His crucifixion and resurrection.

The Triumphal Entry (Matthew 21:1-11)

Prophetic Fulfillment: Jesus' entry on a donkey fulfilled Zechariah's prophecy about the coming king. This was a deliberate messianic claim that the crowds understood and the religious leaders rejected.

The Crowds' Response: The people spread their cloaks and palm branches on the road, shouting "Hosanna!" (meaning "Save now!"). They recognized Jesus as the "Son of David," acknowledging His messianic identity.

The Religious Leaders' Opposition: The Pharisees demanded that Jesus silence the crowds, but He replied that if the people were silent, "the stones would cry out" (Luke 19:40).

Jesus' Tears: Luke records that Jesus wept over Jerusalem, knowing that the city would reject Him and face destruction (Luke 19:41-44).

The Cleansing of the Temple (Matthew 21:12-17)

Righteous Anger: Jesus drove out the money changers and merchants who had turned the temple into "a den of robbers." This act demonstrated His zeal for His Father's house and His authority over the temple.

Prophetic Symbolism: The cleansing symbolized the judgment that would come upon the corrupt religious system and the need for spiritual purification.

Children's Praise: When children continued to praise Jesus in the temple, the religious leaders objected, but Jesus quoted Psalm 8:2 about God ordaining praise from children.

Debates and Confrontations (Matthew 21:23-23:39)

During His final days in Jerusalem, Jesus engaged in several debates with religious leaders:

Authority Questioned: The religious leaders challenged Jesus' authority, but He turned the question back on them regarding John the Baptist.

Parable of the Wicked Tenants: Jesus told a parable about tenants who killed the landowner's son, clearly referring to their plot against Him.

Tribute to Caesar: When asked about paying taxes to Rome, Jesus' answer—"Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's"—avoided the trap while teaching about dual citizenship.

The Greatest Commandment: Jesus summarized the law in two commandments: love God and love neighbor.

Woes Against the Pharisees: Jesus pronounced seven woes against the religious leaders, condemning their hypocrisy and spiritual blindness.

The Widow's Offering (Mark 12:41-44)

Jesus observed a poor widow giving two small coins and declared that she had given more than all the wealthy donors because she gave out of her poverty while they gave from their abundance.

Greeks Seeking Jesus (John 12:20-36)

When some Greeks asked to see Jesus, He spoke about His coming death as the hour for the Son of Man to be glorified. He used the metaphor of a grain of wheat dying to produce much fruit.

The Olivet Discourse (Matthew 24-25)

Jesus' final public teaching focused on the destruction of Jerusalem and His second coming, emphasizing the need for watchfulness and faithfulness.

Theological Significance

Messianic Fulfillment: The events of this week fulfilled numerous Old Testament prophecies about the Messiah's coming and rejection.

Divine Sovereignty: Every detail was orchestrated by God's sovereign plan, even the opposition and betrayal.

Judgment and Grace: The week revealed both God's judgment on sin and His grace in providing salvation.

The King's Humility: Jesus came as a humble king, riding a donkey rather than a war horse, demonstrating the nature of His kingdom.

Reflection Questions

1. How did Jesus' triumphal entry both fulfill and subvert messianic expectations?
2. What does the cleansing of the temple teach us about Jesus' character and mission?
3. How do the debates with religious leaders reveal the hardness of the human heart?
4. What can we learn from the widow's offering about true generosity and devotion?

Key Terms

Triumphal Entry: Jesus' entry into Jerusalem on Palm Sunday, fulfilling messianic prophecy

Hosanna: A Hebrew expression meaning "Save now!" used to praise Jesus

Cleansing of the Temple: Jesus' driving out of merchants and money changers
Olivet Discourse: Jesus' teaching about the end times given on the Mount of Olives

Chapter 16: The Last Supper and Gethsemane

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the significance of the Last Supper and institution of the Lord's Supper
- Explain Jesus' teaching during the final meal with His disciples

- Analyze Jesus' agony in Gethsemane and its theological meaning
- Appreciate the human and divine aspects of Jesus' suffering

Scripture Foundation

"And he took bread, and when he had given thanks, he broke it and gave it to them, saying, 'This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me.'"
(Luke 22:19, ESV)

Memory Verse

"Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done" (Luke 22:42, ESV)

Introduction: The Final Hours

The night before His crucifixion, Jesus gathered with His disciples for the Passover meal. This intimate time included the institution of the Lord's Supper, final teachings, and Jesus' agonizing prayer in Gethsemane.

Preparation for Passover (Luke 22:7-13)

Jesus sent Peter and John to prepare the Passover meal in an upper room. The careful arrangements demonstrate Jesus' foreknowledge and the divine orchestration of events.

The Last Supper (Matthew 26:17-30)

Prediction of Betrayal: Jesus announced that one of the disciples would betray Him, causing great distress among the twelve. Judas' question—"Is it I, Rabbi?"—revealed his guilty conscience.

Institution of the Lord's Supper: Jesus took bread and wine from the Passover meal and gave them new meaning:

- The bread represented His body, broken for them
- The wine represented His blood, shed for the forgiveness of sins
- The meal was to be repeated in remembrance of Him

The New Covenant: Jesus spoke of His blood as "the blood of the covenant," establishing a new covenant between God and His people.

Washing the Disciples' Feet (John 13:1-17)

Jesus demonstrated servant leadership by washing His disciples' feet, teaching them about humility and service. Peter's initial refusal and then excessive request revealed his impulsive nature.

Final Teachings (John 13-17)

During the meal, Jesus gave His most intimate teachings:

- The new commandment to love one another
- Promises about the Holy Spirit's coming
- The vine and branches metaphor
- Warnings about persecution
- His high priestly prayer

Predictions and Warnings

Peter's Denial: Jesus predicted that Peter would deny Him three times before the rooster crowed, despite Peter's protests of loyalty.

The Disciples' Scattering: Jesus warned that all the disciples would abandon Him, fulfilling Zechariah's prophecy about the shepherd being struck and the sheep scattered.

Preparation for Conflict: Jesus told the disciples to prepare for coming opposition, speaking metaphorically about buying swords.

The Garden of Gethsemane (Matthew 26:36-46)

The Setting: Gethsemane was an olive grove on the Mount of Olives where Jesus often went to pray. The name means "oil press," symbolically appropriate for the crushing Jesus would endure.

Jesus' Agony: Jesus experienced intense emotional and spiritual anguish as He contemplated the cross. His prayer—"Let this cup pass from me"—revealed His human nature's natural recoil from suffering.

Submission to the Father: Despite His anguish, Jesus submitted to the Father's will: "Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done."

The Disciples' Failure: While Jesus prayed in agony, the disciples slept, unable to watch with Him for even one hour. This revealed their spiritual weakness and Jesus' isolation.

Strengthening by an Angel: Luke records that an angel appeared to strengthen Jesus, and His sweat became like drops of blood, indicating the intensity of His struggle.

Theological Significance

The Humanity of Christ: Gethsemane reveals Jesus' full humanity—He experienced real fear, anguish, and the natural desire to avoid suffering.

The Deity of Christ: Jesus' submission to the Father's will demonstrates His divine nature and perfect obedience.

Substitutionary Atonement: Jesus' willingness to drink the "cup" of God's wrath shows His role as our substitute.

The New Covenant: The Lord's Supper establishes the new covenant in Jesus' blood, replacing the old covenant sacrificial system.

Reformed Baptist Understanding

From a Reformed Baptist perspective:

- The Lord's Supper is a symbolic memorial, not a literal transformation of bread and wine
- Jesus' agony demonstrates the reality of God's wrath against sin
- Christ's submission shows perfect obedience that is credited to believers
- The disciples' failure illustrates human weakness and need for grace

Reflection Questions

1. What does the institution of the Lord's Supper teach us about remembrance and covenant?
2. How does Jesus' agony in Gethsemane reveal both His humanity and His love for us?
3. What can we learn from the disciples' failure to watch and pray with Jesus?
4. How does Jesus' submission to the Father's will provide an example for believers?

Key Terms

Lord's Supper: The sacrament instituted by Jesus using bread and wine to commemorate His death

New Covenant: The covenant established by Jesus' blood, replacing the old covenant

Gethsemane: The garden where Jesus prayed before His arrest **Agony:** Intense physical and emotional suffering

Chapter 17: The Trials, Crucifixion, and Death of Jesus

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the legal and political aspects of Jesus' trials
- Explain the physical and spiritual aspects of crucifixion
- Analyze the theological significance of Jesus' death
- Appreciate how Jesus' death accomplishes our salvation

Scripture Foundation

"And about the ninth hour Jesus cried out with a loud voice, saying, 'Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani?' that is, 'My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?'" (Matthew 27:46, ESV)

Memory Verse

"And Jesus cried out again with a loud voice and yielded up his spirit" (Matthew 27:50, ESV)

Introduction: The Ultimate Sacrifice

The trials, crucifixion, and death of Jesus represent the climax of God's redemptive plan. Through these events, the sinless Son of God bore the penalty for human sin and accomplished salvation for all who believe.

The Arrest (Matthew 26:47-56)

Judas' Betrayal: Judas led a crowd of soldiers and officials to arrest Jesus, identifying Him with a kiss—a sign of affection turned into an act of betrayal.

Jesus' Submission: Though Jesus could have called twelve legions of angels to defend Him, He submitted to arrest to fulfill Scripture.

The Disciples' Flight: All the disciples abandoned Jesus and fled, fulfilling His prediction and leaving Him alone to face His suffering.

The Jewish Trials

Before Annas (John 18:12-14, 19-23): Jesus was first taken to Annas, the former high priest and father-in-law of Caiaphas. This preliminary hearing was likely to gather evidence for the formal trial.

Before Caiaphas and the Sanhedrin (Matthew 26:57-68): The formal trial before the Jewish council sought to find grounds for a death sentence. When witnesses couldn't agree, the high priest asked Jesus directly if He was "the Christ, the Son of God." Jesus' affirmative answer was deemed blasphemy.

Peter's Denial (Matthew 26:69-75): While Jesus was being tried, Peter denied knowing Him three times, just as Jesus had predicted. Peter's bitter weeping showed his remorse.

The Roman Trials

Before Pilate (Matthew 27:1-2, 11-26): Since the Jews couldn't execute Jesus themselves, they brought Him to Pilate, the Roman governor. They changed the charge from blasphemy to treason, claiming Jesus made Himself a king.

Before Herod (Luke 23:6-12): Learning that Jesus was from Galilee, Pilate sent Him to Herod Antipas. Herod questioned Jesus but received no answer, so he mocked Him and sent Him back to Pilate.

Pilate's Attempts to Release Jesus: Pilate found no fault in Jesus and tried several ways to release Him:

- Offering to release either Jesus or Barabbas (the crowd chose Barabbas)
- Having Jesus scourged, hoping this would satisfy the crowd
- Washing his hands to symbolize his innocence

The Final Sentence: Under pressure from the crowd and fearing a riot, Pilate condemned Jesus to crucifixion despite declaring Him innocent.

The Crucifixion (Matthew 27:27-56)

The Mockery: Roman soldiers mocked Jesus as "King of the Jews," placing a crown of thorns on His head and a purple robe on His shoulders.

The Way to Calvary: Jesus carried His cross until Simon of Cyrene was compelled to help Him. Women of Jerusalem wept for Him, but Jesus told them to weep for themselves and their children.

The Crucifixion: Jesus was crucified between two criminals at Golgotha ("Place of the Skull"). The soldiers cast lots for His clothing, fulfilling Psalm 22:18.

The Inscription: Pilate placed a sign above Jesus' head reading "This is Jesus, the King of the Jews" in Hebrew, Latin, and Greek.

The Seven Last Words: Jesus spoke seven times from the cross:

1. "Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do" (Luke 23:34)
2. "Today you will be with me in paradise" (Luke 23:43)
3. "Woman, behold, your son... Behold, your mother" (John 19:26-27)
4. "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Matthew 27:46)
5. "I thirst" (John 19:28)
6. "It is finished" (John 19:30)
7. "Father, into your hands I commit my spirit" (Luke 23:46)

The Death of Jesus

Supernatural Signs: When Jesus died, several supernatural events occurred:

- Darkness covered the land from noon to 3 PM
- The temple veil was torn from top to bottom
- An earthquake shook the ground
- Tombs were opened and saints were raised

The Centurion's Confession: The Roman centurion declared, "Truly this was the Son of God!" (Matthew 27:54)

The Piercing: To ensure Jesus was dead, a soldier pierced His side with a spear, and blood and water flowed out.

Theological Significance

Substitutionary Atonement: Jesus died as our substitute, bearing the penalty for our sins. His cry of forsakenness shows that He experienced the full weight of God's wrath against sin.

Propitiation: Jesus' death satisfied God's justice and turned away His wrath from sinners.

Redemption: Jesus paid the price to redeem us from slavery to sin.

Reconciliation: Jesus' death removed the barrier between God and humanity, making peace possible.

Victory Over Evil: Though it appeared that evil had triumphed, Jesus' death was actually the defeat of Satan and the powers of darkness.

Reformed Baptist Understanding

From a Reformed Baptist perspective:

- Jesus' death was a definite atonement for the elect
- The atonement fully satisfied God's justice
- Jesus' active and passive obedience are both necessary for salvation
- The benefits of the atonement are applied by the Holy Spirit through faith

Reflection Questions

1. How do the trials of Jesus reveal both human injustice and divine justice?
2. What does Jesus' prayer for His enemies teach us about forgiveness?
3. How do the supernatural signs at Jesus' death confirm His divine identity?
4. What does "It is finished" mean for our salvation?

Key Terms

Crucifixion: A Roman method of execution involving nailing or tying the victim to a cross

Substitutionary Atonement: The doctrine that Jesus died in place of sinners **Propitiation:** The satisfaction of God's wrath through sacrifice **Golgotha:** The place where Jesus was crucified, meaning "Place of the Skull"

Chapter 18: The Resurrection - The Cornerstone of Faith

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to:

- Understand the historical evidence for Jesus' resurrection
- Explain the theological significance of the resurrection
- Analyze the various resurrection appearances
- Apply the truth of the resurrection to Christian living and hope

Scripture Foundation

"He is not here, for he has risen, as he said. Come, see the place where he lay."
(Matthew 28:6, ESV)

Memory Verse

"And if Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile and you are still in your sins" (1 Corinthians 15:17, ESV)

Introduction: The Victory Over Death

The resurrection of Jesus Christ is the cornerstone of the Christian faith. Without the resurrection, Christianity would be just another failed religious movement. But because Jesus rose from the dead, we have assurance of forgiveness, eternal life, and ultimate victory over sin and death.

The Burial of Jesus (Matthew 27:57-66)

Joseph of Arimathea: A wealthy member of the Sanhedrin who was secretly a disciple of Jesus asked Pilate for Jesus' body. He wrapped it in linen and placed it in his own new tomb.

The Women's Witness: Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of James watched where Jesus was buried, planning to return after the Sabbath to anoint His body.

The Guard and Seal: The religious leaders asked Pilate to secure the tomb to prevent the disciples from stealing the body. Pilate granted their request, and the tomb was sealed and guarded.

The Empty Tomb (Matthew 28:1-10)

The Women's Discovery: Early Sunday morning, Mary Magdalene and the other Mary came to the tomb and found it empty. An angel had rolled away the stone and was sitting on it.

The Angel's Message: The angel announced that Jesus had risen and invited the women to see the empty tomb. He instructed them to tell the disciples that Jesus would meet them in Galilee.

The Women's Response: The women left with fear and great joy, running to tell the disciples. Jesus met them on the way and confirmed the angel's message.

The Guards' Report: The guards reported what had happened to the religious leaders, who bribed them to say that the disciples had stolen the body while they slept.

The Resurrection Appearances

To Mary Magdalene (John 20:11-18): Jesus first appeared to Mary Magdalene at the tomb. Initially mistaking Him for the gardener, she recognized Him when He called her name.

To the Women (Matthew 28:9-10): Jesus appeared to the group of women returning from the tomb, confirming the angel's message and instructing them to tell the disciples.

To Peter (Luke 24:34, 1 Corinthians 15:5): Though not described in detail, Jesus appeared privately to Peter, likely to restore him after his denial.

To the Emmaus Disciples (Luke 24:13-35): Jesus walked with two disciples on the road to Emmaus, explaining how the Scriptures pointed to His suffering and resurrection. They recognized Him when He broke bread.

To the Ten Disciples (John 20:19-23): Jesus appeared to the disciples in a locked room, showing them His hands and side. He breathed on them and gave them the Holy Spirit.

To Thomas and the Disciples (John 20:24-29): A week later, Jesus appeared again when Thomas was present. Thomas's doubt was transformed into worship when he saw Jesus' wounds.

To Seven Disciples at the Sea (John 21:1-14): Jesus appeared to seven disciples who had gone fishing, providing a miraculous catch and preparing breakfast for them.

To the Eleven in Galilee (Matthew 28:16-20): Jesus gave the Great Commission to make disciples of all nations.

To More Than 500 (1 Corinthians 15:6): Paul mentions an appearance to more than 500 people at once, most of whom were still alive when he wrote.

The Ascension (Acts 1:9-11): Forty days after His resurrection, Jesus ascended to heaven in the presence of His disciples.

Evidence for the Resurrection

The Empty Tomb: All accounts agree that the tomb was empty. Even Jesus' enemies didn't dispute this fact but tried to explain it away.

The Transformation of the Disciples: The disciples were transformed from fearful, scattered followers into bold witnesses willing to die for their faith.

The Testimony of Women: In first-century culture, women's testimony was not highly valued, making it unlikely that the Gospel writers would invent female witnesses.

The Conversion of Skeptics: James (Jesus' brother) and Paul (a persecutor of Christians) became believers after resurrection appearances.

The Growth of the Church: The explosive growth of the early church in Jerusalem, where the resurrection was proclaimed, suggests the reality of the event.

The Observance of Sunday: The change from Sabbath (Saturday) to Sunday worship reflects the significance of resurrection Sunday.

Theological Significance

Vindication of Jesus: The resurrection vindicated Jesus' claims about His identity and mission. God's raising Him from the dead was divine approval of His work.

Victory Over Death: The resurrection demonstrated Jesus' power over death and His victory over Satan, sin, and the grave.

Justification: Paul teaches that Jesus "was raised for our justification" (Romans 4:25). The resurrection proves that God accepted Jesus' sacrifice for our sins.

Guarantee of Our Resurrection: Jesus' resurrection is the "firstfruits" of the resurrection of all believers (1 Corinthians 15:20).

Present Power: The same power that raised Jesus from the dead is available to believers for Christian living (Ephesians 1:19-20).

Future Hope: The resurrection gives believers hope for eternal life and the ultimate restoration of all creation.

Reformed Baptist Understanding

From a Reformed Baptist perspective:

- The resurrection is a historical fact, not merely a spiritual symbol
- It demonstrates God's power and validates the gospel message
- It assures believers of their justification and future resurrection
- It provides the foundation for Christian hope and perseverance

The Great Commission (Matthew 28:18-20)

Jesus' final recorded words in Matthew's Gospel commission His followers to:

- Make disciples of all nations
- Baptize them in the name of the Trinity
- Teach them to obey His commands
- Trust in His presence and authority

This commission is based on Jesus' authority as the risen Lord and is empowered by His promise to be with His people always.

Reflection Questions

1. What evidence for the resurrection do you find most compelling, and why?
2. How does the resurrection change our understanding of death and suffering?
3. What does Jesus' appearance to doubting Thomas teach us about faith and doubt?
4. How should the reality of the resurrection affect our daily lives and priorities?

Key Terms

Resurrection: The raising of Jesus from the dead on the third day **Empty Tomb:** The tomb where Jesus was buried, found empty on Easter morning **Firstfruits:** Jesus as the first of many to be raised from the dead **Great Commission:** Jesus' command to make disciples of all nations

Unit 4 Review and Assessment

Unit 4 Summary: In this final unit of Semester 1, we have studied the climactic events of Jesus' earthly ministry: His triumphal entry into Jerusalem, the Last Supper and Gethsemane, His trials and crucifixion, and His glorious resurrection. These events represent the heart of the gospel and the foundation of our faith.

Key Concepts to Remember:

- The fulfillment of messianic prophecy in Jesus' final week
- The institution of the Lord's Supper and the new covenant
- The substitutionary nature of Jesus' death for our sins
- The historical reality and theological significance of the resurrection
- The Great Commission and its implications for Christian mission

Scripture Memory Review:

- Matthew 21:9 - "Hosanna to the Son of David!"
- Luke 22:42 - "Not my will, but yours, be done"
- Matthew 27:50 - "Jesus... yielded up his spirit"
- 1 Corinthians 15:17 - "If Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile"

Semester 1 Conclusion: We have completed our study of the life of Christ, from the historical context of His coming through His death and resurrection. In Semester 2, we will study the birth and growth of the early church and the foundational letters of the New Testament.

SEMESTER 1 FINAL REVIEW

Major Themes of Semester 1

God's Sovereignty: Throughout Jesus' life and ministry, we see God's sovereign control over all events, from the political circumstances of His birth to the timing of His death and resurrection.

Fulfillment of Prophecy: Jesus fulfilled numerous Old Testament prophecies, demonstrating that He is indeed the promised Messiah.

The Kingdom of God: Jesus' teaching and ministry revealed the nature of God's kingdom—both present and future, spiritual and physical.

Salvation by Grace: Jesus' life, death, and resurrection accomplished salvation for all who believe, demonstrating that salvation is by grace alone through faith alone.

Discipleship: Jesus called people to follow Him with total commitment, showing that true discipleship involves both privilege and cost.

The Person of Christ: The Gospels reveal Jesus as fully God and fully man, the perfect mediator between God and humanity.

Preparation for Semester 2

Having studied the life of Christ, we are now prepared to study how His followers carried on His mission after His ascension. In Semester 2, we will examine:

- The birth of the church at Pentecost
- The missionary journeys of Paul
- The foundational letters of the New Testament
- The challenges and growth of the early church

The foundation we have laid in studying Christ's life will help us understand how the early church proclaimed His gospel and established Christian communities throughout the Roman Empire.
